MERE ORTHODOXY

Christian Formation in the Modern World

11 essays

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Introduction

What does it mean to be formed as a Christian—not merely to know the right things, but to become the right kind of person? These essays take that question seriously, approaching it from theology, pastoral care, psychology, technology, work, the body, and the life of the mind.

Taken together, they offer something more than a practical guide. They are themselves an act of formation: patient, careful, rooted in tradition, and convinced that the renewal of the church and culture depends not on better strategies but on deeper formation in Christ.

Union with Christ and the Life of Faith

JOSHUA HEAVIN

Three unions lie at the heart of the Christian faith: the union in the Holy Trinity of the three persons who are one God; the two natures, truly human and truly divine, that are united in the one person of Jesus Christ, our Lord and Savior; the union of Christ and his church that the Holy Spirit effects through faith.

These unions lie at the very heart of our faith, yet they are deeply mysterious. God has revealed them to us by his Word, yet they are full of inexhaustible and infinite meaning that we strain to comprehend. We need a learned and devoted guide to explain these mysteries and their significance for the Christian life as a whole.

For those searching for such guides, Fred Sanders's short and accessible new book is a must-read not only for scholars but especially for preachers, teachers, and catechists (with the caveat that some vocabulary is above the lay level). What follows is an overview of the strongest contributions made in the book's five chapters, followed by three questions for further reflection.

The opening chapter advances the most provocative yet intuitive claim in this book—that "the

historic Christian creeds (Apostles' and Nicene) teach that salvation consists in union with Christ." In short, the creed's second article on what we believe about Christ eloquently states how redemption was accomplished, before the third article on the Holy Spirit expresses how that redemption is applied to us. This is very easy to miss altogether. Sanders explains:

The classical creedal-patristic articulation of union with Christ was so wrapped up in tracing the identity of Jesus and narrating his work that the conventional wisdom of our age sometimes fails to recognize it as soteriology at all. It was so baked into the creedal matrix that we are in danger of thinking they were talking about not union with Christ but just Christ himself. We can learn from something here: a doctrine of union with Christ should rivet our attention on Jesus Christ... the structure of Christian faith is itself a form of union with Christ; its first movement is rapt attention to Christ himself and its second movement is inclusion in him.

A key benefit of having a creedally-rooted soteriology is that it will not only be scriptural but will also illumine a common testimony that all Christians share in the divided body of Christ. This is not wishy-washy or lowest-common-denominator ecumenism, but a robust theological vision of what all Christians have always believed —namely, that union with Christ is at the heart of our common faith, expressed in the Apostles' and Nicene creeds we confess together.

Subsequently, in chapter 2, Sanders argues that a theology of union with Christ informs the very structure of the New Testament canon. Modern historicist scholarship has spilt oceans of ink trying to identify the genre of the gospels, or why this particular genre (whatever it is) was used by early Christians to create what Justin Martyr called "memoirs" of Jesus. Still others have puzzled over why a collection of occasional letters to specific churches became religious texts. However, Sanders argues that a theological vision of union with Christ is the clue as to why we have both 'gospels' and 'epistles' in our New Testament canon. Exploring union with Christ is not merely a matter of paraphrasing Paul's many "in Christ" phrases, though they are certainly important. Sanders explains:

Gospels... are not inert genres; they do not sit still and wait for application. They are instead the primal and inescapable literary form of the self-presentation of the risen Christ. They are in themselves already documents of union with Christ, and the implied reader is a disciple united to Christ's life by faith... One benefit of gaining insight into the spiritual structure of inclusion in Christ is that it changes our posture toward the overall message of Scripture. Even while we continue to read the Bible to find its witness about union with Christ, we become aware that the Bible itself exists, in the very literary forms and genres in which it exists, because it is itself situated in Christ. Union with Christ is what summoned these particular genres of prophecy and promise, Gospel, and epistle.

Of course, the gospels are not merely narrations of how salvation was accomplished, since they contain exhortations. And the epistles are not bare statements of salvation's application, since they presuppose some narrative of God's saving action in Jesus Christ. Even so, a theology of union with Christ as the key to salvation's objective

accomplishment and subjective application, holds great explanatory power for considering why our New Testament canon took shape as it did.

The third chapter shows how a range of Christian traditions has explored the union with Christ, not always in the same idioms or emphases, but nonetheless with a common trinitarian and Christological core. Sanders is a perceptive reader of Calvin in particular, who famously declared that all Christ suffered and accomplished would be of no use if Christ remained outside of us, and we outside of him.

Sanders provides a sobering, cautionary tale of how a theologian can have a strong central vision of union with Christ but evacuate it of its theological backbone. His case study, William Sherlock, developed an elaborate account of union with Christ, but without beliefs about a mysterious joining of believers with Christ. Rather, Sherlock interpreted this language to refer to belief in Christ's teachings, obedience, and participation in the life of the church. As Sherlock writes, "it is not very intelligible how we can be or abide in the Person of Christ; and it is more unintelligible still, how we can be in the Person of Christ, and the Person of Christ at the same time be in us, which is a new Piece of Philosophy called Penetration of divisions." Edward Polhill offered an astonishingly lengthy and insightful response to Sherlock, arguing that real, spiritual union with the person of Christ was the foundation on which all other goods cohere.

With those creedal, scriptural, and historical contexts in place, the fourth chapter of this book develops a dogmatic soteriology of union with Christ. This chapter deserves closer attention in light of three contributions it makes.

First, Sanders enters into conversation with the Reformed tradition on the question of whether or not having a robust doctrine of union with Christ is compatible with having an ordo salutis (order of salvation). Sanders argues that union with Christ "is bigger, stronger, more organic, more primal, and more inclined to rivet our attention on Jesus Christ himself than is the ordo salutis tradition, but a well-explained order of salvation, even presented in chart format, can certainly play a valuable supporting role."

Second, Sanders boldly argues we need to cease and desist from speaking about "atonement theories" and instead contemplate a robust vision of our union with Christ as the key to not only redemption's application but also its accomplishment. Though not explicitly conversing with him, Sanders makes a very similar argument to that of Khaled Anatolios in his Deification Through the Cross. Sanders argues: "modern discussions of the atonement have long been in notable disarray—and it is a kind of disarray that is antithetical to the unified treatment of union with Christ we are pursuing. There is fragmentation in modern atonement theology that needs to be repaired before we can begin to understand union with Christ as embracively including both the accomplishment and application of redemption."

Sanders here draws heavily upon Adam Johnson's research on the history of atonement theology, which notes that the modern predilection for identifying various theories as a competing system has its roots in F.C. Baur's Hegelianism, but was hitherto unknown in the history of Christian

theology. Hegel's "theories of atonement" model is so profoundly influential that many of us are unaware of its sources and can hardly think about the atonement apart from it. Yet Sanders cheekily notes that this approach:

...has a tendency to make students feel immediately wiser than all previous theologians (who were evidently never so flexible in their way of thinking about the subject and never even knew that they were operating with theories). As a settled set of presuppositions, or as the new orthodoxy about atonement, it is historically misleading, and it systematically hobbles in advance the possibility of thinking large, integrative thoughts about soteriology.

Instead, the path forward, following Johnson and John Webster, "is not theories but Theoria, the Greek word for contemplation."

Third, it is a false dichotomy to be anxious whether our theology should be Christocentric or trinitarian in its focus, because Christology and the Trinity are concentrically related in the architecture of a Christian theology of salvation. The problem or tension that not only academic theologians but also lay Christians might feel is framed as follows:

There is a perceived difficulty in maintaining a concrete, definite focus on Jesus Christ as the center of salvation while also undistractedly recognizing the presence of God the Father and God the Holy Spirit in the same work. There is a felt tension, in other words, between soteriology's Christocentric impulse, on the one hand, and its trinitarian impulse, on the other. This tension continues to be felt even among evangelical theologians who know there can be no real contradiction between the two. It is a tension that registers troublingly in the spirituality of ordinary believers.

On one hand, it is utterly obvious, correct, and healthy to focus on Christ because "our grasp of salvation is surest when it is most centered on Christ, when we look to him for 'our whole salvation and all its parts,'" quoting Calvin. Yet, danger can also lie down this path, because while "the doctrine of union with Christ certainly seems to be a Christocentric soteriology, ... yet it thrives and flourishes in an elaborately trinitarian setting." After all, modalists and Arians and Socinians in their own heretical ways highly value union with Christ. Consequently, "when people ask whether our thinking should be Christ-centered or Trinity-centered, the obvious reply is to reject the false dichotomy being offered... if Christ and the Trinity are separate centers, they can only be related elliptically, or eccentrically. But they are instead concentric." In sum:

We start our doctrine of union with Christ conceptually by placing Christ at the center of it and then inquiring about Christ's own center. When we realize that his center is the Father, we recognize that in terms of good doctrinal order, we must in fact approach soteriology from the doctrine of God. The Father sends the Son to save in salvation history because the Father eternally begot the Son. It is because of the Son's eternal generation within the Godhead that he is the one sent forth to save... Gregory of Nyssa puts it this way: 'every operation... has its origin from the Father, and proceeds through the Son, and is perfected in the Holy Spirit.' The one God does all things in this unified from-through-in way.

So, in terms of practical piety, Christians should be a profoundly Christ-centered people, but in so doing we will perceive the communion of the Father, Son, and Spirit as Christ's own center. In terms of dogmatic idiom, our theology should begin with the eternal processions of the Son's eternal generation and the Spirit's spiration. We can then proceed to contemplate the missions of the Son and Spirit. In the undivided, outward works of the one God towards creation, the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit work inseparably to bring creatures into saving union with Christ.

Finally, in chapter five, Sanders notes that although there is tremendous variety in the actual lives lived by those who are united with Christ, union with Christ nonetheless gives a consistent form to the Christian life: "a descent and ascent, a dying and rising to true life," which is quintessentially signified in Baptism and the Lord's Supper. Sanders notes how theologians such as Zanchi, Horatio Bonar, and Walter Marshall in The Gospel Mystery of Sanctification all thought it was possible to distinguish between multiple kinds of unions we have with Christ, quintessentially in Christ's union with humanity by his incarnation, and our union with him already in this age, and one in glory that is not yet fully realized.

Overall, as is characteristic of everything Fred Sanders writes, this book is a joy to read. Sanders is far more than an insightful critic or skilled teacher; his infectious delight in the subject matter shines through. Upon setting this book down I wanted my attention to be ever more riveted upon Jesus Christ, certainly when thinking dogmatically about soteriology, but especially so in my day-to-day life and trials.

Second, a great delight of this book was discovering a host of interlocutors on union with Christ who are too little known. The exchange between Sherlock and Polhill centuries ago has been recycled (unawares, as best I can tell) in the last fifty years of debates in Pauline scholarship on "participation in Christ/union with Christ." Some of these forgotten conversations of the past can and should reframe those contemporary conversations. If there is only one further person I wish Sanders had included, I was surprised that N. Herman Ridderbos did not factor into this book. Including him could have helped Sanders's case on two points. First, Ridderbos coined the phrase historia salutis to complement ordo salutis and frame union with Christ as the link between the two. And second, Ridderbos' Redemptive History and the New Testament Scriptures does not make precisely the same argument about the canon Sanders makes, but nonetheless very similar.

Third, a strength of this book is its brevity. Those who want to probe further into this topic might regard it as a prelude to further reading elsewhere. Given that the topic is massive, I was left wondering how Sanders' approach to union with Christ related to numerous debates in the history of Christian theology over how best to understand union with Christ, from intra-Lutheran controversies over participation involving Osiander, to numerous intra-reformed debates over the precise nuances of union with Christ, to post-Palamite approaches to theosis and an "essence/energies" distinction in the East, to post-Tridentine Roman Catholic approaches to union/participation.

For a practical or pastoral example, I have often found that speaking about our "union with Christ" or "participation in Christ" in popular

parlance is heard by not a few people as a reference to our ongoing relationship with Jesus Christ. This is certainly important. However, as Sanders is well aware, the objective accomplishment of our salvation in Christ is something the Holy Spirit subjectively applies in the concrete, particular details of our ongoing relating to Christ through the means of grace.

It can be challenging when preaching or teaching at the popular level to clearly and consistently communicate that vision. Much work remains, but those who attempt to undertake it can do so by building upon the joyful trajectory sketched by Fred Sanders, riveting our attention on Jesus Christ.



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How the Creed, Lord's Prayer, and Ten Commandments Ground Spiritual Formation and Soul Care

HAYDEN NESBIT

I have learned that an essential part of cultivating a flourishing garden is recognizing one simple fact: all plants are not created equal. Some thrive in direct sunlight; others wither under its heat. Some exhibit incredible resilience in the face of neglect; others are temperamental to the slightest environmental changes. Tending to each successfully requires acknowledging its distinct nature.

This is a reality that extends far beyond the garden: before we can ask how best to assist in the flourishing of something, we must ask "what kind of thing is it?" In other words,

nature determines nurture.

There is a chasm of dissonance between our obsessive attempts to practice "self-care" and our fundamental misunderstanding of what kind of thing we truly are. Our confusion about our nature has led to less-than-flourishing results. This confusion, Samuel James says, follows a certain internet shaped logic––the logic of self-creation and self-curation. James argues that a self primarily cultivated through the profile page cannot conceive of a transcendent order to their identity. Simply put, possession of the imago dei is unthinkable for those who have created themselves.

It should be no surprise, then, that we experience increasing exasperation around self-care; we have an innate desire and need to be nurtured, but we have no clue what we need because we have no clue what we are. Our misunderstanding of what kind of thing we are (e.g. our own thing) has led to creating environments that are counterproductive to our flourishing. Options for nurturing self-made persons are untenably open-ended. And as our uncertainty swells, society is happy to assist us in our self-owned endeavor, providing us with various resources laid out by Alan Noble:

Tools (the internet, antidepressants)

Spaces (cities, the suburbs)

Laws (no-fault divorce, free speech defenses of pornography)

Values (efficiency, individualism)

Practices (self-expression, consumption)

And these are not arbitrary resources. Tara Isabella Burton identifies four essential pillars of identity that religion has always provided: meaning, purpose, community, and ritual. Even in the absence of religion these pillars must be filled by something. Consider how Noble is highlighting the inherently religious shape of these societal resources:

We have an intrinsic need to find meaning, purpose, community, and rituals. But these societal resources outlined by Noble work together to construct and pass along a certain "social imaginary"––a cluster of implicit assumptions which skew this pursuit and hold us captive to a secular picture of flourishing.

One of the church's purposes, then, is to nurture believers in accord with their nature in the context of a worshiping community (see Ephesians 4). This task begins with reimagining––or learning for the first time!––what kind of thing we are.

The Nature of the Church

The church is, by nature, a creature of the word. When Calvin said the Word is the soul of the church he was commenting on the inextricable relationship between the two; the word is what gives life to the covenant assembly. Bavinck adds that without the word there would be no church.

The word creates the church. The LORD's voice calls his people out of slavery to be a qahal––an assembly, a congregation. James 1:18 describes the members of this called-out assembly (ekklesia) as being brought forth by the word. Similarly, 1 Peter 1:23 speaks of our being born again through the living and abiding word of God. Salvation for Moses, James, and Peter is, as John Frame describes it, a verbal work of God—not merely

informational but covenantal. God saves by speaking: presenting and applying the person and work of Jesus Christ in a verbal capacity––the euangelion (verbal news) of his sacrificial death and resurrection.

Not only does this word create us, but it creates us as responsive persons. After discussing the (re)creative power of God's divine speech-act in both creation and salvation, Scott Swain goes on to point out that God's various purposes for speaking create various obligations for the hearer: what is proclaimed must be known, what is promised must be trusted, what is commanded must be obeyed, and what is threatened must be feared. Moses informed the qahal after giving them the law (prefaced with the good news of God as Redeemer) that their response was to be worshipful obedience (Ex. 35:1).

Thus, the sole source of our faith and practice is a word that is outside of ourselves and that we must respond to through faith. In other words, we are not our own. Therefore, we cannot—and should not!—set out to determine our own means for nurture. Because the church is a creature of the word, it must be nurtured by that same word. When God speaks, He does so with all of who He is; God is present in the very words He communicates.

Because of this, Swain says, God's communication from him is communion with him. And it is this communion that provides the habitat—the garden—of nurture for the believer. It is Aslan's breath-fueled song that brings the world into bloom. Peter goes on to say that the same living word that birthed us is the very word that continues to nurture us (1 Pt. 2:1-3).

A creature of the word must be nurtured by the word. Historically, such word-centered nurture has taken a concrete, catechetical form that modern self-curated spiritualities cannot replicate.

The Nurture of the Church

Vanhoozer contends that knowing the story of the word––the narrative of Jesus' life, cross, resurrection, ascension, and session––is the proper context for determining our health as humans.

But this word knowledge cannot be reduced to mere information. Scripture, Vanhoozer argues, is not an inert object to be studied; reading the Bible is not an "I-It" relation, but an "I-Thou" affair. Therefore the nurture mediated by this living word must be aimed at what Richard Lovelace termed "live orthodoxy". Encountering this word should not make us mere "brains-on-a-stick" but should cause our dry bones to rattle with life like those in Ezekiel's valley.

However, Lovelace was well aware that sound doctrine does not guarantee heart renewal. His classic work Dynamics of Spiritual Life includes a helpful survey of the dead religion which hastened the Great Awakenings. In his study of such historic revivals and genuine movements of the Spirit, Lovelace outlined a model for cyclical and continuous renewal, complete with a list of elements which must be present in any individual or community who desires to experience this kind of Spirit-infused nurture:

Preconditions of Renewal

Awareness of God's Holiness

Awareness of the depth of our sin

Primary elements of Renewal

Justification

Sanctification

Adoption

Union

Secondary elements

Mission – both word and deed

Prayer – both individual and corporate

Community – both micro and macro

Disenculturation – being freed from the social imaginary

Theological integration – having the mind of Christ

Lovelace's elements can be organized under the common categories recognized for holistic Christian nurture:

While Lovelace's comprehensiveness is helpful, left on our own we will inevitably gravitate toward one end of the spectrum or the other––toward orthodoxy (right thinking) which by itself can foster dry intellectualism, or orthopraxy (right doing) which by itself can foster detached activism. If nurturing "live orthodoxy" is our aim, we need a Spirit-designed shape to help bring balance and integrate these two with orthokardia (right desiring).

Historically, these three have been bound together with a certain approach. Packer and Parrett observe that even a quick survey of the Reformation-era catechisms, as well as later Puritan publications, reveal a shared structure: they nearly all contain certain "ingredients"; namely, expositions on the Apostles' Creed, the Ten Commandments, and the Lord's Prayer. Similarly, in his Enchiridion Augustine notes three primary areas that the Christian must be formed in, following the biblical formula of faith, hope, and love. In addition to this threefold formula, Augustine taught those interested in the faith the narratio––the full sweep of biblical narrative.

We can see how this threefold formula, along with the biblical narrative, encapsulates the necessary elements of nurture and renewal, each being either the environment conducive for or the means to specific areas of nurture:

Many scoff at such an antiquated "program" of nurture via catechesis. After all, the Creed, Prayer, and Commandments can't be purchased (a means Burton says we are encouraged to employ in order to obtain meaning, purpose, community, and ritual!). They aren't marketable and nor do they appeal to our immediacy-trained imaginations. They will not give you the body you desire or grow your follower base. They are, however, ancient touchpoints that are becoming increasingly appealing to a transcendence-seeking culture.

Consider how these are able to provide answers for those seeking identity via Burton's pillars:

In this way, Scripture, the Creed, the Prayer, and the Commandments offer a robust starting line for pillar-shaped nurture in line with our nature as creatures of the word. So yes, consider having direct contact with these three resources. Recite the

Creed alongside your local church, pray the Lord's Prayer corporately and privately, study the Ten Commandments and seek to live them out in direct application of the grace of the gospel. Resources like Packer's Growing in Christ are helpful.

But I am not advocating for a merely flat, curriculum-bound approach to these three. Rather, each should be viewed as an entire way of life.

The Creed should invite us into the renewed life of the mind with its vast peaks and valleys of doctrine as we seek to have the mind of Christ and obey the Lord's invitation to "Know me" (Jer. 29:13)

The Lord's Prayer should welcome us into a lived experience with our Heavenly Father—one marked by the real-life poetry of hearts conforming to His will. *It's worth noting at this point that the Lord's Prayer was taught by the real person of Jesus Christ in the midst of real life to his very real and close friends. That relational context should factor heavily into our Christian experience.

The Commandments should continually broaden, challenge, and reshape our ethics of what it means to love God and neighbor in the specific time and spaces we inhabit with their unique needs.

Now, if this approach feels like a let down––like an underwhelming reach back to an outdated practice, that disappointment may be a symptom of our self-made era which only confirms our need for something not our own. Self-created means of self-nurture are much more innovative and exciting. However, the novelty quickly fades and we're left just as empty and aimless as before. Nature determines nurture, and our nature as imago dei bearing creatures of the Word cannot be meaningfully nurtured and renewed by modern, self-curated means.

We see the futility of modern attempts at nurture when creatures of the word replace holistic, catechetical-shaped, word-centered nurture with the influence of wellness gurus, or the grit of self-mastery programs, or the technologies and techniques of Silicon Valley.

The Creed, the Prayer, and the Commandments are not spiritual techniques to implement or courses to be pounded out and checked off of a discipleship curriculum; they are entry points into the ongoing areas we need nurturing––Christian doctrine, Christian experience, and Christian ethics. Viewed as windows, we can come to each as a starting point, a means through which we see a vast and sacred theological, experiential, and ethical landscape––one inhabited by Jesus himself, and in which we learn to run freely as nurtured children of our God.



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Suffering as Spiritual Formation

JAMES WOOD

I: The Formative Nature of Suffering

When we speak about spiritual formation, we usually focus on intentional practices: Scripture, prayer, sacrament, community, obedience. What is striking, however, is that one of the most powerful forces of formation in the Christian life is not an intentional discipline at all—and yet it is unavoidable. I am speaking of suffering.

Suffering is one of the most transformative realities in human existence, and yet it is often marginal in the literature on spiritual formation. Perhaps that is because it cannot be scheduled, controlled, or optimized. It resists technique. It comes to us unbidden. And yet, again and again, Scripture and Christian experience testify that suffering is among the primary means by which God deepens, clarifies, and reforms his people.

I have sometimes quipped—speaking informally—that suffering is "sacramental." I do not mean that in a technical sense. I mean that suffering is a tangible, material, experiential reality through which spiritual truth is disclosed. It mediates insight. It unveils reality. In that sense,

suffering functions as a kind of apocalypse—not catastrophe, but unveiling. It reveals what is true: about God, about us, and about what ultimately matters.

The Ubiquity of Suffering

We must begin with a simple, unromantic observation: suffering is universal. After Adam's fall and prior to the triumphal return of the Second Adam, suffering is inescapable. That is why the problem of suffering—the question of theodicy—reappears in every generation. Not merely because it is philosophically interesting, but because it is existentially unavoidable. Every person either knows suffering already or will.

This is one reason the book of Job is so important. Some scholars have suggested that Job may be among the earliest written books of Scripture—though this cannot be proven. What we can say is that Job stands strangely outside Israel's normal historical markers. It is set in a kind of cosmic frame, involving heavenly councils and satanic testing, in a way that is almost unique in the canon.

Now consider the significance of this. What if one of the first acts of written revelation God gave to his people was a book about incomprehensible, inexplicable suffering? If so, the lesson is sobering and clarifying: suffering is inevitable, and God is good—but these two truths do not resolve into a neat system. Indeed, God explicitly condemns Job's friends at the end of the book for attempting precisely that.

As Karl Barth observes in Church Dogmatics IV/3 (§70.1–2), the book of Job demonstrates that suffering cannot be fitted into a coherent explanatory scheme without distorting God himself. Barth describes the friends' counsel as falsehood in its "classical and sublimest form"—the falsehood of piety. Their theological propositions are, in themselves, largely correct. Yet they speak these truths timelessly and clichédly, abstracted from the concrete encounter between God and the suffering man before them. As a result, their speech becomes "a counterfeit which only resembles the truth."

The God of the friends, Barth insists, is not an active and living God but one confined within a moral system—orderly, predictable, and ultimately unfree. "But this unfree God is not the God of Job." Consequently, Job cannot recognize himself in what they say, nor can their theology account for the man actually confronted by God in suffering. Speaking "from the standpoint of heaven," non-historically and within a closed explanatory framework, they turn truth itself into untruth. Their "stereotyped speeches" fail because they do not deal well with the encounter between God and man in suffering.

Yet suffering is not meaningless. In Job, God "wins" his wager with Satan—Job remains faithful. But Job also learns. He learns that God is sovereign even over suffering, that divine wisdom far exceeds human comprehension, and that God is worthy of trust even when his ways appear unjust. Most strikingly, Job's suffering leads to deeper encounter: "I had heard of you by the hearing of the ear, but now my eye sees you" (Job 42:5).

This pattern recurs throughout the history of God's people. Those who suffer in faith often testify, in retrospect, that they would not change their suffering—not because it was pleasant, but because of what God did through it. Many speak

of a nearness to God during trials that they have never otherwise known.

This is not universally true. Suffering does not automatically sanctify. As Augustine insists in The City of God, what matters most is not the nature of the suffering but the nature of the sufferer—what use the suffering is put to (City of God, I.8). Suffering reveals character. It exposes what we love. It can school us for eternity (I.29), loosening our grip on temporal goods and reordering our desires.

Suffering in Scripture: Christ as the Pattern

If we want to understand suffering as formative, we must begin with Christ. Hebrews 5:8 makes the startling claim that Jesus, "though he was a Son, learned obedience through what he suffered." This is mysterious. It does not imply moral deficiency in Christ, but it does indicate suffering's pedagogical function.

If this is true of the Son, we should not expect another path for those who are united to him. Formation, after all, is conformity to Christ. And Hebrews makes this explicit in chapter 12, where suffering is framed as the loving discipline of a Father who treats us as sons. This discipline is "for our good, that we may share his holiness." Formation is discipleship, and discipleship includes not only practicing the disciplines but being disciplined by God.

Paul develops this theme with remarkable clarity. In Philippians 3, he recounts the losses he has endured and declares them worth it for the surpassing value of knowing Christ. He goes further: he expresses a desire to "share in Christ's sufferings" in order to become like him. Suffering is not incidental to Christlikeness; it is one of its primary means.

The same logic appears in Romans 8. We are heirs with Christ, Paul says, "provided we suffer with him in order that we may also be glorified with him." There is a real connection here. Earlier, in Romans 5, Paul describes suffering as a process that produces endurance, character, and hope—hope grounded not in stoicism but in the love of God poured into our hearts by the Holy Spirit.

Peter echoes this in 1 Peter, a letter written almost entirely under the sign of suffering. The whole letter is effectively about embracing suffering as Christians, following in the footsteps of our savior, knowing that our pattern will be his—suffering unto glory; humiliation unto vindication. Here in the opening lines Peter brings up the various "trials" which grieve us. These, he indicates, are also a form of testing—they reveal the genuineness of our faith. But this test doesn't just reveal, it refines—resulting in praise and glory at Christ's appearing. Suffering, biblically understood, is not merely diagnostic; it is transformative.

Suffering as Clarification and Deepening

One of the most evident effects of suffering is its capacity to deepen a person. Those who have suffered often carry a particular gravity: their counsel bears greater weight, their compassion has greater density, and their words are fewer, but truer. By contrast, those largely untouched by suffering tend to offer counsel that may be technically correct yet existentially thin.

Why is this so? Because suffering clarifies.

Consider post-apocalyptic stories. There are many compelling examples—A Quiet Place, Children of Men, Station Eleven, The Last of Us. My favorite is The Road. To read or watch it as a father is devastating. In McCarthy's world, civilization has collapsed. The landscape is dark and dangerous, stripped of comfort and distraction. And yet, precisely because everything extraneous has been removed, what is essential comes into sharp focus. For the unnamed protagonist—simply "the man"—every concern is subordinated to a single priority: the preservation and care of his son.

This is one of the enduring strengths of the genre. Post-apocalyptic narratives force a ruthless concentration on what matters most. They depict worlds denuded of distraction, where the fundamental questions of love, responsibility, and hope can no longer be deferred. I would argue that suffering performs a similar function in our lives. It quiets the noise. It brings ultimate concerns to the foreground. What matters now can no longer be postponed.

Scripture speaks of glory (kābôd) in terms of weight. Suffering teaches us what is weighty. It exposes first- and second-commandment failures. It reveals whether we have elevated something in creation above God, or whether we have fashioned a god according to our expectations—one who exists to secure our desired outcomes. In suffering, we discover whether we trusted God himself, or merely a version of God who guaranteed certain goods.

We are thus compelled to come to terms with the holy God who tolerates no rivals, and who yet most fully reveals himself in the suffering of the cross (John 12). Any vision of God that cannot endure the pressure of suffering is an idol—and idols must be broken.

The secular worldview insists that this world is all there is. Suffering confronts that claim with urgency. It presses eternity upon us. The Puritans understood this well. They saw suffering as a purifying reminder that we are strangers and pilgrims, loosening our attachment to this-worldly things and sharpening our desire for heaven.

Paul says it plainly: "The sufferings of this present time are not worth comparing with the glory that is to be revealed" (Rom. 8:18). Suffering, when endured in faith, teaches us to build our nest not here but in Christ, to desire the better country, the city whose builder and maker is God—where suffering will finally be no more.

II: Suffering in Ministry

If suffering is formative for the Christian life in general, it is even more so for those called to represent Christ publicly. Ministry, by its very nature, places us at the intersection of Christ and a fallen world. And that intersection is marked by suffering.

Scripture is remarkably clear on this point: those who identify with Christ should not be surprised when they suffer. In fact, we should expect it.

Jesus makes this explicit at the very beginning of the Sermon on the Mount—a text foundational for spiritual formation. In the Beatitudes, Jesus does not say if you are reviled and persecuted for my sake, but when (Matt. 5:11). Opposition is assumed. And yet, he says, we are to rejoice—not because suffering is good in itself, but because it locates us within a larger eschatological horizon:

"your reward is great in heaven."

Jesus reinforces this expectation in the Upper Room Discourse. As he prepares his disciples for life without his physical presence, he prepares them for hostility. "If the world hates you," he says, "know that it has hated me before it hated you." And then the clarifying principle: "A servant is not greater than his master." Identification with Christ necessarily entails participation in his rejection.

1 Peter: Suffering as Witness and Vocation

Nowhere is this theology worked out more pastorally than in 1 Peter—a letter addressed to believers who are suffering precisely because they are Christians. Peter frames suffering not as an interruption of discipleship but as one of its primary modes.

In chapter 2, Peter describes enduring unjust suffering as a "gracious thing" in God's sight. Why? Because it allows believers to walk in the footsteps of Christ himself. Christ "also suffered for you, leaving you an example," entrusting himself to the one who judges justly (1 Pet. 2:19–23). Suffering, here, is not only endured; it is imitative. It conforms us to Christ's pattern of trust and nonretaliation.

Peter presses this further in chapter 3. Christians are not to return evil for evil, but to bless those who oppose them. They are not to fear those who attack them for bearing witness to Christ. Instead, they are to honor Christ as Lord in their hearts—and, in that very context, to be ready to give a defense for the hope that is within them (3:14–15).

This is worth underscoring. The most famous apologetics proof-text in the New Testament is not about abstract argumentation. It is about embodied witness under pressure. Christian apologetics, at its core, is not merely intellectual; it is cruciform. Enduring unjust suffering with integrity puts accusers to shame—not primarily by outwitting them, but by exposing the moral and spiritual depth of Christian hope (3:16).

Peter then draws the conclusion explicitly: "Do not be surprised at the fiery trial when it comes upon you." Again, surprise is inappropriate. Suffering is expected. And yet Peter says more: "Rejoice insofar as you share Christ's sufferings, that you may also rejoice and be glad when his glory is revealed" (4:12–13). Such believers are called "blessed," because "the Spirit of glory and of God rests upon them" (4:14).

This entire argument leads directly into Peter's exhortation to elders in chapter 5. Shepherds, too, must expect suffering. They must entrust themselves to God, resist the devil who seeks to devour them, and remember that this pattern of suffering is shared by the whole family of God across time and place. Ministry does not exempt one from suffering; it intensifies it.

Suffering as Public Testimony

Why does Scripture place such weight on suffering in ministry? Because trusting God in suffering glorifies him before others. It displays the worth of God. The supernatural joy and comfort and peace which can withstand the worst the world can unleash.

We see this vividly in the life of Stephen. Saul—who would become Paul—was present at

Stephen's trial and execution (Acts 8:1). Luke tells us that as Stephen was violently opposed, his face appeared "like the face of an angel" (6:15). As his accusers raged, Stephen, "full of the Holy Spirit," gazed into heaven and saw the glory of God, and Jesus standing at the right hand of God (7:55).

Stephen bears witness not only by what he says, but by how he suffers. And as he is stoned, he prays for his executioners, echoing the prayer of Christ himself (7:60; cf. Luke 23:34). This Christlike suffering does not halt the mission of the church—it accelerates it. Those scattered by persecution go out preaching the word (Acts 8:4). Even Saul himself is eventually confronted by the risen Christ and converted (Acts 9).

Paul never forgets this. He understands his own suffering as part of the same pattern. Christ tells him from the outset that he will suffer for the sake of the name (Acts 9:16). And Paul repeatedly interprets his afflictions not as failures of ministry but as instruments of its advance. His imprisonment, he tells the Philippians, has served to advance the gospel by emboldening others to speak the word without fear (Phil. 1:12–14).

This leads Paul to make one of the most counterintuitive claims in the New Testament: suffering for Christ is a gift. "It has been granted to you," he writes, "that for the sake of Christ you should not only believe in him but also suffer for his sake" (Phil. 1:29). This, Paul says, is part of living a life "worthy of the gospel of Christ" (Phil. 1:27).

Ministry, then, is not conducted exclusively in favorable conditions. Faithful witness endures pressure. Suffering is not alien to that witness; it can be an occasion for some of the most profound witness. When ministers endure suffering with faith, hope, and love, they make visible the reality of the gospel they proclaim. And it is precisely this cruciform faithfulness that God so often uses to advance his kingdom.

III: Suffering for Ministry

Up to this point, we have considered suffering as something disciples should expect and endure as they represent Christ in a fallen world. But Scripture presses the question further. Suffering is not only something that happens to those who follow and represent Christ; it is something God intentionally uses—and at times even appoints—for the sake of our peculiar ministries.

Nowhere is this clearer than in the life and theology of the Apostle Paul. Paul speaks frequently of his sufferings (2 Cor. 4; 6; 11; 2 Tim. 3:10-12; etc.), but he does more than recount them. He interprets them theologically. He understands his afflictions not merely as obstacles to ministry, nor simply as the unavoidable cost of faithfulness, but as instruments through which God shaped him into the kind of minister he was called to be.

We have already noted one effect of Paul's suffering: it emboldened others. His endurance under persecution strengthened fellow believers and advanced the gospel. But Paul also testifies that God worked directly through his afflictions to preserve the integrity of his ministry and his own spiritual health.

This comes into focus in 2 Corinthians 12, in the well-known passage concerning the "thorn in the flesh." Paul, by his own admission, was richly gifted: an unparalleled missionary, a theological mind of exceptional depth, and a recipient of

extraordinary revelations. God had entrusted much to him. And God also acted to guard him as one so gifted.

We are not told what the thorn was. What we are told is that Paul desired its removal. He prayed earnestly that God would take it away (12:8). God did not grant that request. Paul comes to understand this not as neglect or severity, but as divine wisdom: the thorn was given to keep him from becoming conceited because of the surpassing greatness of the revelations he had received (12:7).

God's response reframes Paul's understanding of ministry: "My grace is sufficient for you, for my power is made perfect in weakness" (12:9). The issue was not weakness itself, but how strength can obscure dependence upon God. Through this experience, Paul learns to boast—not in his gifts or successes—but in his weaknesses, "so that the power of Christ may rest upon me."

As a result, Paul adopts a distinctive ministerial posture. He embraces "weaknesses, insults, hardships, persecutions, and calamities" so that Christ can be exalted in his ministry, in his own mind (12:10). "When I am weak," Paul says, "then I am strong" (12:10). Through these, Christ's power is displayed.

There is a clear pastoral lesson here for those preparing for ministry. God's withholding of visible success or immediate fruit is not necessarily a failure of calling. It may be a form of protection and preparation. Weakness in ministry is not something to flee, nor are delays or setbacks reasons for despair. Nor should we measure our faithfulness by comparison with others. We do not yet see the whole of what God is doing—either in us or through us.

One of the wisest prayers a future minister can offer is this: Lord, do not let my platform outpace my character. A large platform received too quickly often proves spiritually dangerous. The public failures of gifted leaders who rose rapidly should caution us against equating visibility with readiness or faithfulness.

But Paul's theology of suffering for ministry does not end with restraint. Suffering also prepares us. Prior affliction equips ministers to serve others with depth, patience, and genuine consolation. To see this, we must turn earlier in 2 Corinthians, to one of Paul's most concentrated reflections on ministry—chapters 1 through 5—where suffering becomes not merely a personal burden, but a means through which God brings comfort, reconciliation, and life to others.

Suffering as Preparation for Service

In the opening chapters of 2 Corinthians, Paul offers one of the richest expositions of faithful ministry in the New Testament. Ministry, he insists, is conducted in sincerity, not as peddlers of God's word, but as those who speak in Christ and rely entirely upon God's action (2:17). Ministers do not commend themselves; they depend on the Spirit who alone gives life (ch. 3). For this reason, faithful ministers renounce manipulation, refuse to tamper with the word of God, and reject every form of cunning. They proclaim Christ, not themselves (4:1–5).

Confidence in ministry, for Paul, does not arise from personal strength or visible success, but from trust that God works through ordinary

means—the preached word (4:6, 13)—and through extraordinary weakness. We are, as Paul famously puts it, "jars of clay," fragile vessels through whom God displays his surpassing power (4:7ff). Ministry is therefore conducted with an eschatological horizon in view: ministers fix their eyes not on what is seen, but on what is unseen; not on what is temporary, but on what is eternal (4:18; 5:1ff). All of this is ordered toward one end: that God may be glorified as people are reconciled to him.

What is especially striking, however, is how Paul begins this entire discussion of ministry. Before he speaks of integrity, proclamation, or reconciliation, he speaks of suffering and comfort. God, Paul says, comforts us in all our afflictions so that we may be able to comfort others with the very comfort we ourselves have received from him (1:4). This comfort is inseparable from participation in Christ's sufferings (1:5). Paul goes so far as to say that his afflictions are "for your comfort and salvation," and that even his consolation serves the same end (1:6).

In other words, Paul understands his suffering not merely as a personal trial, nor simply as the cost of apostleship, but as preparation for ministry to others. As God meets him in affliction, Paul is formed into an instrument through whom God can meet others. The grace he receives becomes the grace he mediates.

This is one of the profound reversals of the gospel. God so thoroughly overturns the curse that suffering intended for harm becomes a source of healing. The very places where the servant of Christ has been wounded become the places from which ministry most powerfully flows—if we allow Christ to meet us there. Those who have been comforted by God in their affliction become, in turn, agents of comfort, offering others the same medicine by which they themselves were healed.

Paul concludes this dense section with an eschatological frame that gathers everything together. Though we are wasting away outwardly through what he calls "momentary affliction," we are being renewed inwardly, even now, in preparation for "an eternal weight of glory beyond all comparison" (4:16–17). Suffering, then, is not the end of the story. For those in Christ, it is often the place where God is doing his deepest preparatory work—shaping ministers who are fitted not only to proclaim the gospel, but to embody it.

Your suffering is not the end. In the providence of God, it may well be a beginning.



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On Communicating Truth, Goodness, and Beauty

JAKE MEADOR

In the past I sometimes taught a high school writing and literature class for a homeschool coop back in Lincoln. In the first week of class, I gave my students an assignment I lifted from Robert Farrar Capon's book The Supper of the Lamb, which is a kind of basic theology of creation dressed up like a cook book. Capon's book is written as a guide that ostensibly will help you grow as a home chef by over time learning a complex and elaborate recipe in which you prep a whole lamb that will feed eight people four times. In reality he is teaching you a love of the world God has made through a series of short culinary meditations.

The book begins with an exercise in which he demands that his readers spend one hour slicing an onion: He provides instructions for how this should be done and more commentary than you would imagine possible on the intricacies of a single onion.

So in the opening week of my class, I assigned my students the task of spending one hour slicing a single onion and then writing a few paragraphs for me about the experience. To this day I am somewhat amazed that I never got a single confused or angry email from a parent, but I never did.

Why would I do such a thing? Partially, I suppose for mischievous reasons to see what a group of teenage homeschool kids would do in response to being made to do such a task. But there were better reasons also closely related to Capon's own purposes in the book: Learning to cook in the way Capon imagines it, including learning to prep that absurd lamb recipe, requires more of a person. It actually requires something deeper and more challenging of you–you need to not simply memorize a recipe or gather ingredients or chop them up and heat them up. You actually need to understand a bit about cooking–techniques, the interplay of ingredients, and what happens to x if you do y. It requires the combination of close attentiveness to particulars and a sufficiently broad and deep knowledge that you can feel your way through a complex task.

What it requires, in other words, is less an ability to do a single mechanical task or a series of mechanical tasks, and more a capacity to understand ingredients, understand techniques, understand the interplay between them, and out of that complex knowledge assemble something beautiful.

So I want to start my time today by making a distinction now between those two things: abilities and capacities. When I speak of an ability, I mean the sort of thing that one can do with minimal thought or engagement, the sort of thing that can be explained via a short bulleted list.

To remain in the kitchen, quickly dicing a carrot is an ability. Browning some ground beef is an ability.

To expand to other categories, when I ask my ten year old son to put his laundry away, that is an ability.

It is not that these things require nothing of us: If I am going to dice a carrot I need to know wear the carrots are, where the knife is, how to cut with the knife, etc. If my son is going to put his laundry away, he needs to know where the laundry is and where it is supposed to be.

So one does need some rudimentary skill when dealing with abilities. But they do not ask much of us.

Capacities, by contrast, are somethingng that cannot be simply distilled to a bulleted list in the same way. If I asked you to prepare a meal for eight people using the food on hand in the cupboards and refrigerator, you can't simply look at a list of seven steps and complete the task. You need to acquire a certain sort of copiousness about yourself which allows you to be given what many would see as a daunting task and discern how it can be done.

To again consider my children, if I asked my son to "help your mom around the house while I am away" or I asked him to go talk to his sister before going to bed to patch things up after a fight they'd had earlier in the day, those are not simple "abilities." One can try to render them as such, of course, but we all recognize the insincere offer of help, the forced apology, and we regard them as something diminished or lesser. To do these things is not an ability, but a capacity, for they can only be done when we acquire certain generalized characteristics, even in very minimal or basic ways, that allow us to do these things.

When we talk about communicating persuasively with other people or expressing an idea in a

beautiful way or helping someone perceive the good in a more profound way, we are working in the domain of capacities, not abilities.

I am starting here because I think there is a danger we can fall into very easily in talking about how to communicate truth, goodness, or beauty with neighbors who have different ideas of the good life than we ourselves do. We live in a fairly superficial, distracted cultural moment. You do not need to sit in solitude with your thoughts anymore–a myriad of distractions are always readily at hand. And this reality creates a certain superficiality that defines much of our world now. We have become people who lack a certain depth of character, depth of spirit, depth of soul. And yet developing capacity is in many ways another way of saying acquiring depth.

Because of this, it has become easy for us to largely forget the whole notion of capacity and instead think that everything we do in life can be reduced to abilities, provided we consult with the right person–or LLM. Thus the rise of AI therapists, to take but one example.

So when we talk about doing the things we are thinking about right now given all of that cultural background, it is very easy to get lost or frustrated because when we try to reduce the capacities required to do such things down to mere ability we find that it doesn't work, that these things cannot be reduced to mechanical steps or bullet points, anymore than the sublime beauty of a certain moment we might encounter in life can be distilled down to a photograph or a series of numbered steps.

In other words, the problem before us is not one of technical mastery. And that is hard for us, I think. We are tempted, perhaps especially in a place like DC, to evaluate ourselves as persons in terms of our place within our economic system. So we are primarily producers and our value is bound up in our ability to master technical skills enabling us to solve discrete problems which lead to greater production, efficiency, wealth, and so on.

That isn't the issue though. We are called as Christians toward a certain mode of life I can't give you a step by step guide to do the things we are talking about today. What I can try to do is tell you about the kind of person who is able to do these things and commend to all of us–myself very much included because I also struggle for depth–the characteristics and ways of living that allow a person to acquire such capaciousness. So that is the frame I want to work within as we have this conversation. With what remains of the time, I want to do two more things:

First, I want to think for a bit about the characteristic excellencies that help someone mature and deepen in their encounter with the Christian faith and their ability to communicate it. There are three characteristics, or you might even call them virtues, that I want to commend to you:

Attentiveness

Some years ago a friend of mine, then a PhD student in New Testament at a program in the UK, shared a story with me of an encounter he had at a theological conference. He was at his hotel in the downstairs area getting breakfast when an older woman sat down at the table next to him. She was attempting to get her breakfast, but her elderly

hands were struggling to open the packet of oatmeal. My friend offered to help. So he opened the oatmeal packet, gave it back to her, and they began to talk. The woman was deeply interested in his work–asking him questions about his dissertation, the scholars he was reading, and so on. The woman was clearly quite knowledgeable in the field and asked perceptive, probing questions that forced my friend to think more carefully about the project.

But what most impressed my friend was not actually the caliber of her questions, as great as that was. What he noticed first of all was that at no point in the conversation did this woman appear to grow distracted, bored, or as if she was searching for a way to exit the discussion. If you attend enough professional or academic conferences, you soon begin to recognize a certain sort of interaction you will have several times at each event: You're speaking to a person, but they aren't really looking at you or even listening, actually. Rather, they are distracted. Perhaps they seem anxious. Tellingly, they will glance over your shoulder every so often, as if scanning the room for more worthy or advantageous conversation partners.

This woman my friend was sitting with did none of that. She was fully absorbed in the conversation, even as it was plainly of no real advantage to her. After breakfast the two went their separate ways and it was only then that someone went up to my friend and asked him what he had been talking to Katherine Sonderegger about for so long. And that is how my friend realized he had been in conversation for the past hour with one of the greatest dogmatic theologians of her generation.

I share the story to illustrate a point: Attentiveness is a kind of resource we have and our dispensing of that resource is indicative of the health of our heart. When we spread our attention thinly, we become superficial. When we direct our attention only to what can materially benefit us, we become selfish and egotistical. But there is another option: We direct our attention to that which is worthy of it–and there is much in the world that answers that description. Sunsets and birds and trees and even the sound of the wind can all be worthy of our attention. So too is your neighbor. And the reason your neighbor is worthy of your attention is not because of what they might offer you, but simply because they are. They share in the gift of being itself which God gifts to us as his sons and daughters. And so they are interesting and worth attending to–and this applies as much to the homeless person you pass on the street without a thought as it does to your boss at work or the wealthy and successful businessman at your church.

Patience

Attentiveness can be sustained only by patience–one way of defining the act of patience is to say that it involves hopefully enduring some form of suffering which we judge to be less than the good we hope to obtain if we will wait and endure until it is obtained. Minimally, then, patience is what allows us to continue to be attentive.

But Augustine also argues that patience has a restorative quality to it. In his treatise on patience —and isn't it telling that so many early church fathers wrote entire treatises on the virtue of patience?—Augustine says,

For this is just, that we who from our first felicity of Paradise for contumacious appetence of things to enjoy were dismissed, through humble patience of things that annoy may be received back: driven away for doing evil, brought back by suffering evil: there against righteousness doing ill, here for righteousness' sake patient of ills.

So patience transforms us. For our purposes here, your ability to discern and communicate what is good, true, and beautiful will be enriched and deepened through the practice of patience. So it is not just that patience allows you to keep attending to the good things you are already watching. It is also that the practice of patience will open your eyes to new good things to which you can then attend. The slave trader turned abolitionist preacher and hymn writer John Newton once wrote, "When I hear a knock at my study door, I hear a message from God. It may be a lesson of instruction; perhaps a lesson of patience: but, since it is his message, it must be interesting."

Hope

Finally: We do not know how God will work or what he will do through us. But we know that God is at work and that he routinely is pleased to use us as means for accomplishing his ends. So when we are attending to his word and his world and when we are learning to love both and when we are attacked by things which we must patiently endure as we seek to attend to the world, we do this with a spirit of hope because we know that God is full of love and compassion, that he desires that no one would perish, that he hates injustice, and that he sometimes will use us to further his purposes in the world. We do not know when that will be or how he might do it, of course, but we trust that he will because we hope in his promises.

Second, I hope to offer three specific bits of counsel that are hopefully at least somewhat more immediately actionable for us as we go about our work.

Shun perfectionism.

People are finite, fallible, and sinful. That includes your peers you are working with and trying to communicate with and it includes you and me. What this means is that our attempts to convey and apply what is true are hindered both by our own limitations and shortcomings and by the same from our neighbors. There are two particular applications here for this point that need to be made:

First, that people are broader and stranger than you think and are capable of surprising you–when we treat people as vehicles for ideological projects we miss this point.

Second, that you are not going to ever arrive at pristine coalitions or bills, and that even triumphs will have elements of failure within them. These are simply the conditions of our life in the world–and, by the way, apply to all vocations, not just the work of government. You can confront this reality and respond to it in anger because it disappoints you, frustrates you, or challenges you. Or you can confront this reality and let it make you more merciful, humble, and forbearing.

Live on the razor's edge.

I am taking this from Tim Keller who offered this exact council to his parishioners in the Redeemer

family of churches in New York. The point is that seeking to live in this way in a mixed society of belief and unbelief inherently requires accepting a certain measure of ambiguity and complexity, as well as the genuine chance of failure.

The difficulty here is that if you do want to practice patient attentiveness and reckon with politics as they actually work, then these are the table stakes. There is no possibility of perfection, nor any chance of the immediate and complete realization of perfect justice. All we are left with is the complexity and tension of life in the world as it is. If you would be faithful in such a world, then you will necessarily live on the edge, because there is simply no other way of life that avoids these intractable difficulties. Far better to accept this and entrust yourself to God's kindly care while availing yourself of his means of grace then to do anything else.

Identify points of contact.

Finally, identify the points of overlap or common concern with colleagues, neighbors, peers, etc. Recall the story of Paul in Athens. Who are the unknown gods that your peers worship in ignorance? Recall also that, as Augustine taught us, evil is nothing; it lacks substance. For that reason, a person virtually never desires evil itself. Rather, they err by confusing something that is evil for the good or they err by failing to value something appropriately.

This reality creates a variety of opportunities for Christians. In the domain of politics, where many of you work, it means there are many places where you might find common cause on a given issue with a surprising partner or ally. In the domain of relationships and church life, it means that there are ample entry points for talking about Christ and the Gospel, if only we would have our eyes open to them, and it means that no stranger is so far removed from you that they must remain permanently at a distance. For those who attend to the words of Christ and devote themselves to his way of life, another life is possible. Thank you.



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The Necessity of Gratitude

NELSON MUSIPA

Gratitude is an attitude that is highly cherished culturally, socially and more so in the Christian life. Ingratitude on the other hand is frowned upon. In my culture ingratitude is likened to the sin of witchcraft. People are called out for failing to show gratitude.

Culturally every time I do some act of kindness to my relatives, they express their gratitude and pronounce a blessing over my life. Gratitude is cherished in most cultures.

When it comes to the Christian life, gratitude is imperative. It is taught, commanded and commended as a way of life for Christians. It is something that should flow out of one's relationship with Christ and an understanding that I brought nothing in this world and everything I have is a gift.

"Enter his gates with thanksgiving and his courts with praise; give thanks to him and praise his name. For the Lord is good and his love endures forever; his faithfulness continues through all generations." (Psalms 100:4-5 NIV)

How does gratitude play out in a Christian's life? First there is gratitude towards God for who he is and for what he has done and is doing for us. We must recognize that he is the source and

sustainer of our lives.

"For who makes you different from anyone else? What do you have that you did not receive? And if you did receive it, why do you boast as though you did not?" (1 Corinthians 4:7 NIV)

This is something that Job recognized and acknowledged, even after losing everything. Despite his loss he was not filled with bitterness but praise and worship that flowed from a heart of gratitude.

"At this, Job got up and tore his robe and shaved his head. Then he fell to the ground in worship and said: "Naked I came from my mother's womb, and naked I will depart. The Lord gave and the Lord has taken away; may the name of the Lord be praised." In all this, Job did not sin by charging God with wrongdoing." (Job 1:20-22)

Gratitude flows easily and naturally when I accept that life owes me nothing and neither does anyone owe me anything. Lately as I have visited sick friends and family in hospital some of whom are totally incapacitated, I have become grateful for the gift of full body functionality.

I realize that each person I see lying in bed, sick and incapacitated, did not choose to be in that position. Therefore, the fact that I can sit up on my bed, stand, and take a shower is a gift for which I am thankful.

The second area in which we need to show gratitude as Christians, is towards others for their commitment to God and service to his people. Being grateful for how God is at work in and through others helps me to positively encourage them instead of seeing them as competitors.

"We always thank God for all of you and continually mention you in our prayers. We remember before our God and Father your work produced by faith, your labor prompted by love, and your endurance inspired by hope in our Lord Jesus Christ." (1 Thessalonians 1:2-3 NIV)

The third area to show gratitude is for what God is doing in and through us to fulfill his purpose as we serve him and his people. This should never be used as something to draw attention to us or make a name for ourselves. Instead we should be grateful for the opportunity to participate in what God is doing.

One of the things that kills gratitude is a sense of entitlement and attachment to things. If I live as though God and the world owes me something it's hard to have a heart of gratitude. When I feel unappreciated and that am not recognized for my role and contribution, I complain and grumble instead of being grateful.

"Suppose one of you has a servant plowing or looking after the sheep. Will he say to the servant when he comes in from the field, 'Come along now and sit down to eat'? Won't he rather say, 'Prepare my supper, get yourself ready and wait on me while I eat and drink; after that you may eat and drink'? Will he thank the servant because he did what he was told to do? So you also, when you have done everything you were told to do, should say, 'We are unworthy servants; we have only done our duty.'" (Luke 17:7-10 NIV)

Ultimately gratitude is a mark of the Christian life. It helps me to stay focused and balanced in my service to God and his people. Wherever gratitude is missing there is strife, competition, and

complaining, all of which hinder progress and fruitfulness in the Christian life.



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The Good News About Bad Work Days

ELIZABETH STICE

Very often, when we talk about faith and work, we talk about vocation. We encourage people to find and follow their calling, not just to pursue wealth or worldly success. Vocation is a very good thing and those are very good conversations.

But not everyone finds their vocation. And while vocation is also closely tied to the idea of fulfillment, sometimes our work is unfulfilling.

As a result, conversations about faith and work can be hard for some people to enter and the ideas surrounding faith and work can even be a bit alienating. When we talk about faith and work, we should also be talking about sanctification.

Work can be a place where we find great fulfillment and meaning, but work can also be a source of great disappointment and frustration. We distinguish between work and toil, but even if the work we do is more than toil, we are not guaranteed good bosses or ideal circumstances. You might not get the promotion or raise you expect, even the one you deserve. You may do great work and your company may still go under. You may be called upon to make personal sacrifices

for the greater good and never see that rewarded. These are all normal work experiences.

Work can lead to burnout. Though "job burnout" is not a medical condition, it is taken seriously by medical professionals. The Mayo Clinic identifies the causes of burnout as: lack of control, lack of clarity about what's expected of you, conflicts with others, too much or too little to do, lack of support, and problems with work-life balance. The American Psychological Association is also concerned with worker burnout, which is linked to psychological conditions like depression, insomnia, and psychological distress and to physical conditions like heart disease, headaches, and musculoskeletal pain. According to the Society for Human Resource Management, in 2024, as many as 44 percent of workers felt burned out, 45 percent felt "emotionally drained" by work, and 51 percent felt "'used up' at the end of the workday." At the end of 2024, Pew Research reported that: "Half of U.S. workers say they are extremely or very satisfied with their job overall. Another 38% say they are somewhat satisfied, and 12% are not too or not at all satisfied with their job."

Many people are somewhat miserable at work or are sometimes made miserable by work. "Dream jobs" are elusive. Even seemingly great and desirable jobs might require long hours or great effort. The Bible establishes that work is good, but the experience of work can be frustrating as often as it is fulfilling. It can be hard to make sense of this reality, especially considering how many hours of our lives are spent at work, whether or not we love it. We all want meaningful work, but we also have to make sense of the meaning of the hard work we do and what it takes from us.

When we think about our work and our faith, we should be considering what to draw from the difficult parts and what it means that so many of us will end up feeling like we have given more than we have received at work. Viewing work as a means of sanctification can help people derive more meaning from work, even when the job and the results do not align with dreams or vocation. Sanctification is understood as the process of making something or someone holy, associated with spiritual growth and increased alignment of our will with God's. Sanctification involves smoothing our rough edges and slowly dying to ourselves.

While the home is central to our existence, many of us spend more of our awake hours at work than at home, which means something in terms of how we should evaluate the significance of how we experience, and are experienced at, work. Many of the exhortations of the New Testament can relate directly to workplace experiences. Consider Jesus' admonition not to worry, given in Matthew 6 and Luke 12. It is human to worry, because we lack control and our future is uncertain. Our lack of control exists in many parts of our lives, but it can be exceptionally stressful at work, where we are often dependent on our co-workers and bosses and even the whims of the economy. We have all the parts of our lives to learn to trust God more when we experience a lack of control, but we have an average of almost eight hours per weekday to do that at work.

Many people have a "work bestie," but most of us do not choose all, or even most, of our co-workers. The question of "who is my neighbor?" is a pressing one at work. As in the parable, our neighbors are not necessarily the people we select, they are the people in the neighboring cubicles, or down

the hall, or on the same presentation team. We have no genetic predisposition to love our co-workers and, often, no familial ties to secure our affection. The people we work with are, outside of family, the people whose lives we can do the most to improve. Even if your work is about benefiting specific, other people, it is unlikely you spend more time with the target population than you do with your co-workers.

Day after day, year after year, we work alongside people whose strengths and weaknesses and personal struggles we can come to know intimately. We have the opportunity to love and serve these people, not as benefactors but as neighbors. Some of us may have leadership roles, but most of us will make our most meaningful contributions to the lives of others as peers or even as subordinates. Caring for our co-workers has less glory than a missions trip and co-workers will know better than most people how well developed we are in the fruits of the Spirit. Work gives us the opportunity to love our neighbors—the ones we are gifted, not the ones we choose—as our most human, exhausted, overworked selves.

Sometimes work is miserable. Who has not labored in a bad workplace situation? Who has not waited to be recognized or promoted or even paid? Who has not been challenged by confusing processes or silly protocols? What good comes of this? Much good can come of this. Work is a place where we learn to increase our patience and restrain our tempers. We are not at liberty to say or do whatever we feel or please when we are unhappy, not if we want to remain employed.

A challenging workplace can be a context we can use to practice and integrate many virtues. Wages stagnate, bonuses do not always arrive, co-workers have different compensation for the same jobs. How will we handle ourselves and how will we evaluate our worth when compensation might be unfair or our efforts seem underappreciated? Can we understand our work as being "unto the Lord" as Paul advised in Colossians? Even when the pay is good but the effort is exhausting, we must build a narrative around what is required of us—will we see it only in terms of our exhaustion or exploitation or can we transmute that into something more meaningful?

One reason we are so often inclined to narrate our workday at home is because that is the only way we can be the center of the story of the workplace. We are rarely even the center of the floor we work on. Whatever work we do, it goes beyond us and is not built exclusively around our wants and desires. We can resist the lessons in this reality, or we can use it as a reminder that we are not in the center of the universe and that is a very good thing.

There are many goods we can derive from work even when work does not always seem good. The ideal is work that is fulfilling, but we can be well-formed even by work that is not. Arguably, the workplace struggles we experience are some of our best opportunities for sanctification. Thinking about work and sanctification can help us toward a richer understanding of the ways that work is a blessing, even when it does not feel especially satisfying. Bringing sanctification into the conversation around work can help us move toward a more robust theology of work.



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The Dark Triad and the Death of Repentance

JAKOB Y. KIM

It begins in the pulpit—or perhaps, if we are honest, it begins in ourselves. I have seen it in churches, in leaders I once admired, and at times in the mirror: the inability to say, "I was wrong."

We preach grace and speak of repentance, yet we rationalize and reposition. We ask for prayer but not forgiveness. We call for revival but rarely confess. We proclaim grace, but weep not. And we are not alone.

Psychologists speak of a "Dark Triad"—Machiavellianism, narcissism, and psychopathy—not merely as a taxonomy of antisocial traits, but as a framework with moral implications. These traits resist remorse, responsibility, and grace. Their defining feature is not mere immorality but a structural incapacity for contrition. One need not be a criminal to fit the profile. Some smile, charm, lead—and devastate—without ever acknowledging fault. Their conscience does not fail; it is suppressed.

This raises a theological question of grave importance: What occurs when the human will,

already bent by sin, ossifies into a structure fundamentally closed to repentance? Reformed theology rightly teaches that repentance is not a human achievement but a divine gift. Yet even divine grace, though irresistible in the elect, often meets fierce resistance until it breaks through. What if certain personalities, apart from divine intervention, lack the psychic architecture to conceive of themselves as sinners?

Martin Luther described sin as incurvatus in se—a turning inward of the self. In this light, the unrepentant are not simply stubborn; they are enthroned. They do not so much reject grace as find it unintelligible. John Calvin observed that repentance is born of faith—that is, it begins not in self-awareness but in the death of self-sovereignty.

The Westminster Confession defines repentance unto life as a saving grace whereby a sinner, out of a true sense of sin and an apprehension of God's mercy in Christ, turns from sin unto God with grief and hatred. But what becomes of repentance when grief is absent—when there are no tears? When sin is rebranded as strength, and guilt is reframed as pathology? In such cases, theology confronts the hard edge of moral detachment. As Jean Twenge and W. K. Campbell observe, we live in an age where narcissism is not only tolerated but celebrated—where guilt is pathologized and repentance appears regressive.

Psychologist Joshua D. Miller has observed that grandiose narcissists exhibit strong resistance to moral self-revision. Robert Hare notes that those with psychopathic traits tend to receive confrontation not as care, but as challenge—and respond not with reflection, but with manipulation. Paulhus and Williams, who first coined the term "Dark Triad," emphasize the interpersonal callousness and manipulative orientation inherent in these traits. These are not momentary lapses in judgment but durable dispositions, which may correspond to what Paul calls a "seared conscience" (1 Tim. 4:2): not dead, but cauterized. While the Dark Triad is an imperfect lens, it helps name dispositions that theology has long warned against.

This presents not only a pastoral challenge but an ecclesial crisis. What becomes of a church whose leaders are structurally incapable of repentance? When charisma deflects correction, and authority insulates from accountability, the congregation ceases to be a flock and becomes a firewall. The gospel, in such contexts, is not proclaimed but performed—without tears, without sorrow, without death. And performance is what unrepentant hearts often master.

Such figures are not rare. They are present not only in pews but on stages. They offer no confession, respond to confrontation with rhetorical maneuvering, and pursue therapy as strategy rather than healing. Their apologies serve not as admissions but as instruments of control. They do not seek restoration but leverage.

We need not imagine far-fetched scenarios. In the wake of recent evangelical scandals—from celebrity pastors to fallen movements—the pattern is hauntingly consistent. A leader builds a vast ministry, preaches grace weekly, and teaches repentance as spiritual maturity. Yet when confronted with credible reports of bullying, manipulation, or moral failure, he responds with evasion. His resignation cites stress, not sin. He soon reappears elsewhere, rebranded and unrepentant. The sheep are

scattered; heaven hears no confession.

Still, grace does not depend on the penitent heart. It creates it. Grace does not await sorrow; it generates it. But this grace must come from beyond. No technique, no therapeutic method, can produce repentance where the self remains enthroned. The way forward is not adjustment but crucifixion—the radical undoing of the self. Only in the death of pride can resurrection begin.

This is why theology must attend to psychology—not to baptize it, but to examine it critically. The Dark Triad is not merely diagnostic; it is apocalyptic. It reveals what becomes of human nature when left to itself. And from such, Jesus says, the kingdom hides.

Yet the gospel reaches even further. The One who knew no sin became sin—even for those who deny sin (2 Cor. 5:21). Christ descends not only into graves of guilt but into tombs sealed by self-worship. Not with flattery, but with fire. Not with affirmation, but with mercy severe enough to break stone.

Repentance is impossible for man. But not for God. He who breathed life into dust can breathe sorrow—even tears—into stone. He who wept at Lazarus's tomb can awaken tears in eyes long dry. "I will give you a new heart," says the Lord, "and put a new spirit within you" (Ezek. 36:26). Even the Dark Triad is not beyond the reach of pierced hands.

And so the Church must recover the ordinary rhythms that make repentance plausible again: weekly confession, transparent elder accountability, and slow pathways back into leadership for the fallen. These are not techniques of grace but rooms cleared for grace to enter.

If we desire renewal, it will not begin with new strategies but with tears. For the Spirit moves where breath is gone, rattles the gates we sealed, and speaks into hearts we deemed unreachable. He does not knock. He enters. He does not negotiate. He resurrects.

A church without repentance is near death. But where death meets the crucified Christ, resurrection waits.

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To Go Forward, We Must Go Backward

IAN HARBER

My first class in college was an introduction to fine arts. You could have easily renamed the class "Introduction to Beauty." One day, our professor took us to the Dallas Museum of Art and gave a guided tour through the different eras and cultures on display. Our assignment was simple: Select one piece of art that captures our attention, study it for as long as necessary, take notes, and write a report on it. Amid all the sculptures, paintings, and installations, I found two that stood out.

The first was Frederic Edwin Church's painting, The Icebergs. If you've never been to the Dallas Museum of Art, you can't quite understand what it's like to stand in front of this painting. It stands nearly five and a half feet tall and is almost nine and a half feet wide. Of course, it's hanging on the wall so it seems even taller. As you turn the corner and enter the room it is in, you don't expect to see a painting its size waiting for you. You walk towards it, stand in front of it, hands clasped behind your back, and it takes up nearly your entire field of vision. You can almost feel the chills from the icy water. Looking at The Icebergs in person is a visually immersive experience.

But I didn't write my report on The Icebergs. I wrote it on a different painting, one from an artist that is decidedly more controversial. I wrote my report on Jackson Pollock's Portrait of a Dream.

Pollock painted Portrait of a Dream almost one hundred years after Frederic Edwin Church painted The Icebergs. Looking at the two paintings side by side should make it obvious why Pollock was and remains so controversial. The Icebergs is a mammoth Romantic landscape that captures the beauty of the scene, plays elegantly with light and composition, and is clearly a masterpiece. Pollock, on the other hand, looks mostly like someone who just threw his wet paintbrush at the canvas.

And yet, as I studied the Pollock painting, I found myself drawn to it more and more. To my surprise, I saw myself in it. The painting is called Portrait of a Dream, after all, and I realized that it did, in fact, resemble the ways that I had processed, or "dreamed," about my life. The dark, chaotic mess that was somehow distant from but also connected to me. I saw the darkness, but only partially. Glimmers of light created warmth on my skin, but my sight was still tainted by the effects of the darkness. Half-seeing, half-blind. Light mixed with dark. Disoriented by the darkness that I knew was there but unable to make heads or tails of it. Only trying to live in the light of what I could see, which wasn't much.

I'm not sure if that is what Pollock had in mind when he painted this or not. It could have been a portrayal of the bipolar disorder that he was believed to have. But I was surprised to find a rather accurate portrayal of my inner world in some seemingly haphazard splatter paint. To many people, Pollock represents the degradation of art in the century between the Romantics and the Abstract Expressionism of the mid-1900s. In some ways, I might agree. And yet, I will never forget the ways that sitting in front of Portrait of a Dream, studying it, taking notes on it, and writing about it, helped me understand my own story.

My experiences with these paintings at the Dallas Museum of Art are far from my only experiences with art. In high school choir, I had the privilege of singing songs like Amor De Mi Alma in the Meyerson Symphony Center and Danny Boy in Irish Cathedrals. Was I any good? Hardly. But these were remarkably transcendent experiences; ones that I'm not sure I fully appreciated at the time. Looking back, I understand now how profoundly formative they were.

Several years ago during a trip to Portland, my wife and I went to a small Mediterranean restaurant we had heard about. Our order was simple: pita bread and hummus. To this day, my taste buds still haven't had anything like it. I didn't even know pita bread and hummus could taste like that. I think about it way more than I'd like to admit. That pita bread and hummus, in their own way, were art.

In the food, I tasted beauty. In the songs, I participated in beauty. In the paintings, I beheld beauty. And this beauty pointed me beyond the mere material in ways that would reverberate throughout my life. Once you've tasted, seen, heard, sang, and felt true beauty, you spend the rest of your life seeking it. You can't unsee what you've seen, unhear what you've heard, or forget what you felt. Through beauty, you've been exposed to a reality beyond yourself. In beauty, in art, you touch the transcendent.

The Small World of Social Media

In October 2024, NPR released a report titled, "TikTok executives know about app's effect on teens, lawsuit documents allege." Let's just say that the report was shocking, but not surprising. To make this abundantly clear, these are findings that come from TikTok's internal reports, meaning TikTok knows these things about itself. Here are some of the things revealed in the report:

TikTok users can become 'addicted' in 35 minutes (or after 260 videos)

TikTok demoted people it deemed unattractive on its feed

TikTok's algorithm could deprive kids of opportunities like sleeping, eating, and looking at someone in the eyes

TikTok's internal estimate indicate that 95% of smartphone users under 17 use TikTok

TikTok pushes users into filter bubbles like 'painhub' and 'sadnotes'

TikTok's content moderation misses self-harm and eating disorder content

TikTok is slow to remove users under 13, despite company policy

TikTok is in crisis mode after reports on TikTok Live being a 'strip club filled with 15-year-olds'

Of course, while TikTok's algorithm seems to have a unique potency to it, this isn't unique to TikTok. The negative social and mental health effects of social media in general are well documented. Jonathan Haidt's much-acclaimed book The Anxious Generation is the best resource for seeing such data. TikTok only stands as the starkest example of the harm social media causes. The worst part is that this is by design. In the digital age, attention is the new oil and algorithms are the drills that extract it.

"What's the problem with watching a few funny videos?" Well, nothing. Until you understand that the medium you're watching the videos on isn't neutral or harmless. These attention frackers don't want you to just watch a few funny videos; they want you to never close the app. What we perceive as simply taking it easy and watching a few funny videos is actually allowing corporate (and potentially foreign national) interests to, metaphorically of course, drill holes in our brains and siphon our attention for profit. It's a fundamentally different medium than say, film or television. Movies and TV shows have a definite run time. At some point it's going to end, whether that is in thirty minutes or three hours. However, even auto-play features on streaming services blur those lines. Regardless, there is an endpoint built into the media.

Social media, on the other hand, is infinite scrolling. It's well documented that the infinite scroll of social media is based on the design of slot machines in casinos. One more pull and you might strike gold. It is these factors and more coming together—ease of access, elimination of choice, infinite scroll, promise of serendipity, illusion of community, quick information, etc—that make social media addicting in ways no other medium is.

Other mediums require you to give your attention and, like books, paintings, songs, and even food,

sometimes will point you to the transcendent. That's what art does. But our phones are different. They're black holes for attention. Social media, when it is primarily used to consume content instead of connecting with others, takes your attention and gives you nothing back.

You can see what this does to us in how our language has changed. Much has been written about the death of boredom. When we picture boredom, we might think of a middle schooler in the 90s bouncing a ball off their wall over and over again. We almost never speak of being bored like this anymore, but it's exactly this kind of boredom that sows the seeds of something greater. Understimulated boredom pushes us into a different kind of life. If we are bored and want to stop being bored, we must use our creativity. The Catholic philosopher Byung-Chul Han connects boredom with contemplation in his work, The Burnout Society.

We owe the cultural achievements of humanity—which include philosophy—to deep, contemplative attention. Culture presumes an environment in which deep attention is possible. Increasingly, such immersive reflection is being displaced by an entirely different form of attention: hyperattention. A rash change in focus between different tasks, sources of information, and processes characterizes this scattered mode of awareness. Since it also has a low tolerance for boredom, it does not admit the profound idleness that benefits the creative process.

As Han points out, achievements in culture and creativity are downstream of boredom. It's in the moments when we aren't overstimulated, or hyperattentive as he calls it, that we can access the contemplative life and, ultimately true relaxation. Boredom allows us to be generative; to produce life beyond ourselves. Han goes on, "If sleep represents the high point of bodily relaxation, deep boredom is the peak of mental relaxation. A purely hectic rush produces nothing new. It reproduces and accelerates what is already available.

Contrast this with Oxford's 2024 word of the year: brain rot. Oxford defines Brain Rot as:

(n.) Supposed deterioration of a person's mental or intellectual state, especially viewed as a result of overconsumption of material (now particularly online content) considered to be trivial or unchallenging. Also: something characterized as likely to lead to such deterioration.

Whereas boredom produces words like contemplation, culture, and creativity, hyperattention to a constant stream of online content produces words like rot, deterioration, and unchallenging. Boredom is generative while hyperattention is degenerative.

Consider this in the context of Psalm 1. The wicked are characterized by walking, standing, and sitting. You might say it's a kind of movement that degenerates to non-movement. But the blessed one is like a tree planted by a stream bearing fruit and never withering. You might say that flourishing looks, paradoxically, like stationary activity. The tree doesn't move, and yet it is active in the seasonal fruit it produces and resilient in how its leaves are alive and well.

So the digital age presents us with two contrasting ways of life to consider that are new expressions of the choices that have always been before us. Psalm

1 calls it wickedness or blessedness. Byung-Chul Han calls it hyperattention or boredom. We might call it flourishing or rotting. Those who want to flourish must reject the digital age's rotten habits and pursue the Psalm 1 life instead. A life of contemplation, creativity, generativity, and yes, even boredom.

The problem with social media isn't that it's too much, it's that it's too little in all the ways that matter. It doesn't expand our world, it shrinks it. To look at my phone, I hunch my neck, lowering my eyes, and curving in on myself. To look at The Icebergs, I stand back, clasp my hands behind me, widen my stance, and look up. To see myself in Portrait of a Dream, I must stand still, concentrate, contemplate, and be okay being uncomfortable. My phone makes me smaller even as it promises more access to the world. Beauty makes me bigger even as I'm swallowed up in a world much larger than I.

What social media provides in information, it lacks in substance. We would do better with less information that is more substantive. The path we walk should take our feet away from the small world of our screens and into, as C.S. Lewis described in his preface to On The Incarnation, "the great level viaduct which crosses the ages and which looks so high from the valleys, so low from the mountains, so narrow compared with the swamps, and so broad compared with the sheep-tracks." In other words, transcendent and eternal realities. You might find that in a book, a symphony hall, an art gallery, a concert, or a restaurant. You'll certainly find it in prayer, scripture, and a healthy local church. But you won't find it on the For You feed.

Mark Sayers notices this in his book, Reappearing Church, when he writes, "We now live in a media-drenched landscape in which endless promises of improvement accompany us throughout our lives. The promises are a post-Christian vision of personal renewal. Emptied of the transcendent, we now reach for reduced visions of the good life, from the quest for physical health to the quest for safety and emotional security in an increasingly risky world."

The vision of the good life we are "drenched" in will form our imagination of what is normal and calibrate the coordinates of our lives in its direction. We won't even realize who we've been walking with until we're sitting down in their vision of life, not our vision for our lives, and certainly not God's vision for our lives. Social media is the straight and narrow for secondhand living.

Swimming Upstream

Few things capture this dynamic better than Ted Gioia's widely praised essay, The State of the Culture, 2024. It still applies today. In it, Gioia illustrated the present situation like this:

Silicon Valley created apps that have taken us beyond art and beyond even entertainment. They distracted us until they finally addicted us. Gioia demonstrates in simple terms how the feedback loop between stimulus, dopamine release, a desire for more, and habit formation has created this addiction. The fish illustration is apt; this is the water we swim in now.

It seems to me that in order to not just survive, but flourish in an age of algorithmic addiction, the only way to go forward is to go backward. To swim upstream. We have to acquire new tastes that

won't be served to us on the platter of the For You feed. Instead of walking into the algorithmic restaurant of information, we have to become hunter-gatherers who go out and find it for ourselves, starting in the places where people said they once found a bounty.

This is going to be uncomfortable, require patience and new skills, and make us seem weird to some of our peers, but as far as I can tell it's the only way out. In The Intellectual Life, the French priest A. G. Sertillanges writes, "Do not be ashamed not to know what you could only know at the cost of scattering your attention. Be humble about it, yes, for it shows our limitations; but to accept our limitations is a part of virtue and gives us a great dignity, that of the man who lives according to his law and plays his part."

If we're going to swim upstream, break our addictions, and make our way back to art, we need some concept of what that could look like. There's a vast number of ways that it could look, but Gioia put together another helpful chart that shows this progression in multiple areas of life.

We might not be in the same place in every category. We might be at Dopamine Culture for Journalism and at Fast Modern Culture for Sports. Regardless, I believe Gioia not only diagnoses the problem but helps us find our way out. For all of the talk about having a Rule of Life right now, this chart should be part of our consideration when we think about our habits and the ways we organize our lives. We should honestly consider where we are on this chart and what it looks like, practically speaking, to go backward. We don't need to do everything in one fell swoop and we'll still need to calibrate it for the reality of our lives (will we really go back to only handwritten letters?). Like Gioia himself said, "We need a slowness revolution in our whole culture right now."

Where can we replace short-form with long-form? Where can we replace digital with physical? Where can we replace loud with quiet? New with old? Fast with slow? Sedentary with activity? Isolation with relationship?

This isn't a mere self-improvement exercise; this is a practical attempt to live the Psalm 1 life and obey the command given to us in James, "My dear brothers and sisters, understand this: Everyone should be quick to listen, slow to speak, and slow to anger, for human anger does not accomplish God's righteousness. Therefore, ridding yourselves of all moral filth and the evil that is so prevalent, humbly receive the implanted word, which is able to save your souls" (James 1:20-21).

This also isn't a luddite rant against everything digital. This is about breaking free from the soul-shriveling tyranny of our devices and breathing the clean air of God's good world again. This isn't about burning everything down; it's about making sure we're operating it more than it is operating us. Myles Werntz is right when he wrote here in Mere Orthodoxy,

"It is here that the point of resistance begins—not with piloting alternative living arrangements or economic systems for their own sake—but living in accordance with [what] is needed for the soul to flourish. And by living in this way, we will find that we no longer need the Machine, but that the Machine always and ever needed us to flourish. What is a social media company without users, or an industrial complex without consumers? It is a

hulking shell waiting to be repurposed, buried, and raised again to new life."

The Buzzing Of The World

It should strike us that one of the fruit of the Spirit is self-control. That, as we walk in step with the Spirit, one characteristic we should expect is greater levels of mastery over ourselves. A growing ability to handle ourselves from an internal locus of control as opposed to being tossed to and fro by the waves of everything around us. Shortly before he was executed, Boethius wrote, "If you are in possession of yourself you will possess something you would never wish to lose and something Fortune could never take away." No matter our station in life regarding our wealth, status, power, or pleasure, if we are in control of ourselves, we have something that can never be taken from us.

What's easy to miss here is that self-control is the end of the list that begins with love, joy, and peace. The end goal of self-control is not apathy or even tranquility, as in mere Stoicism, but aims toward a life filled with love, joy, and peace. Self-control is a prerequisite of self-forgetfulness. Without self-control, you're forced by necessity to think about yourself more than others when you're battered by the wind and waves of circumstances. But when your house is built on a firm foundation, you can withstand the waves and "in humility consider others as more important than yourself" (Philippians 2:3).

This is why it's crucial for us to take back our agency from the algorithms and cultivate a deep interior life that's free from the constant march of content on our feeds, not for vague notions of personal responsibility or the sovereign individual, but to walk in step with the Spirit of Christ, becoming people of love who obey the greatest commandments, and cultivate the virtues of faith, hope, and love in our lives, bearing the fruit of the Spirit in our lives.

This is going to require us to get back to the basics. Daily prayer and scripture. Regular church attendance. Frequent conversations with friends we know in real life. Putting our phones down and reading books, nonfiction and fiction alike. The older the better. How can we tend to the weighty matters of the world when we can't tend to our own soul before God?

Thomas À Kempis wrote in The Imitation of Christ, "Blessed are the ears that are attuned to the soft whisper of God's voice and that ignore the buzzing of the world." Maybe the word we need for today is simply that.

Blessed are the ears that ignore the buzzing of the world.

Blessed are the ears that are attuned to the soft whisper of God's voice.

We need interior wells deeper than attention frackers can drill. We need spaces in our soul that are reserved for God and can't be siphoned off for corporate profit. We must listen for the soft whisper of God's voice in all that is true, good, and beautiful. We must allow ourselves to be captured by beauty, and ignore the buzz in our pockets.

Once more, Thomas speaks to us, "Use the things of the world, but long for the things of eternity." Social media may be of some use to us, I have no doubt about that. But our longings, the words of our mouths, and the meditation of our hearts

must be eternal. For eternity has been placed in our hearts, and if we can lift our eyes from the screen to the hills, with full attention, patiently waiting on the Lord, we will see everything made beautiful in its time (Ecclesiastes 3:11).



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What is Technology Good For?

DRAKE OSBORN

What is technology good for?

For the Christian, the answer cannot be everything or nothing. If technology is good for everything, then the pursuit of the good life moves us further and further away from the simplicity of Eden. If technology is good for nothing, then how do we make sense of God's great use of it, from the detailed engineering of Noah's Ark to the intricate architecture of the new Jerusalem?

Whenever I talk to church members about the use of technology or it comes up in the pulpit as a point of Scriptural application, there is a tendency to hear only extremes.

This is the most common perception I get in the pews: that to faithfully follow Christ in a technological world you must either embrace and utilize or deny and repudiate. Tech Bro or Luddite; the middle is too murky and ripe for hypocrisy. People want to know where, that is, in what areas of life, they can freely use technology, but often find few nuanced answers. The difficulty of the median position is categorical in nature. We simply are not trained to contain our

use of technology into specific spheres of our life. This is true for at least a few reasons.

First, it is difficult to find a middle-ground for technological use because technology is readily advancing and evolving into an all-pervasive reality. In his book What Technology Wants, Kevin Kelly calls this reality "The Technium." No longer are technologies separate techniques for distinct purposes. Instead, due to economic realities as well as the choices of technologists, most technology has now been blended into an interconnected mess of chips and screens and data. Tech builds on other tech, advancing at a multiplicative rate that it begins to take on a kind of autonomy that is very difficult to escape.

Writes Kelly: "At some point in its evolution, our system of tools and machines and ideas became so dense in feedback loops and complex interactions that it spawned a bit of independence." The middle ground of technology is murky because it requires not just a discernment of one technology, but a discernment of the vast, autonomous technium. The reason why it seems like the best strategy against the technium is to pull the plug entirely is because we cannot imagine a world where its individual parts are able to be parsed out and powered down. Very few of us are competent enough to take apart a hard-drive, how much more a billion inter-connected hard drives?

Second, it is difficult to find a middle-ground for technological use because tech companies create products bent towards greater degrees of dependence, which in turn incentivize everyone else toward greater reliance on technology. Consider an older man whose entire life savings is in physical gold, housed in a secure deposit box. His only form of communication is a phone landline. It seems like his life is quite secure, and yet it would be impossible for him to sign up for so much as a rewards account at Chick-Fil-A because he could not pass the online verification process without an email and cell phone. The technium wants you to become fully dependent on it, because that is how it grows larger and more influential. Becoming only slightly dependent on technology is like trying to ride a tsunami: better to get swept away or get out of the way.

Thirdly, it is difficult to find a middle-ground for technological use because doing so is tiring. In his essay The Burnout Society, philosopher Byung-Chul Han observes how the modern west has moved from a "disciplinary society" to an "achievement society." We are no longer defined by what we cannot or shouldn't do, but what we can and should do. Our life is not guarded by restrictions but by freedoms, and the greatest freedoms in life are offered by technological advancement. The promise of the technium is that we can go faster, know more, and achieve greater accomplishment with less and less to hold us back. The result of this thirst for achievement and freedom to achieve is greater rates of burnout, despair, and disillusionment with life. Fighting against the current of achievement society requires training, discipline, patience, and often real suffering.

Even as I am writing this, Google's AI assistant offers to overcome the stress of formulating a new sentence with a few simple keyboard commands. "Help me write," it says, as if it assumes I am quite incapable without its vast knowledge base and unparalleled processing speeds at my fingertips. Should I see what it has for me, trusting in my ability to sift through its content generation and

use it towards my ends? Or should I chuck my expensive laptop at the nearest wall and hope I never have to deal with un-solicited AI prompts again? Surely we can do better.

A few weeks ago I had the privilege of enjoying a retreat at Laity Lodge entitled "Staying Human in an Age of Acceleration" with Andy Crouch and Sho Baraka. Worth the price of admission was Andy Crouch's categories for technological use. Building off his work in The Life We Are Looking For, he helpfully aimed to help us answer the question "What is Technology Good For" by examining its usage in three different spheres of life: preservation (protection), production, and formation. His talks are available online, but I'd like to offer my agreement and commentary on his thoughts as a way forward through the fog and towards a middle ground of technology use.

The Green Light: Preservation

What is technology good for? Crouch argues that it has an inherent good when it is tied to the preservation or protection of life, beauty, and culture. Seat belts save lives; we should not boycott them. X-Ray machines give us helpful diagnoses, and are built for the expressed purpose of preservation. In fact, most of the advanced technology we find at a hospital or clinic fits into this category, reminding us that the pursuit of medicine is a common grace of God, who is the great healer and preserver of life.

Throughout human history, technology has been used to advance the preservation of society and culture. The previously mentioned Ark of Noah served this purpose: to preserve a remnant of creation from the wrath of God. What Noah saved was not just genetic material, but also the human story, the soft goods of culture passed from him to his offspring after him.

The reason that technological advancement aimed at protection and preservation can be more readily embraced is because, in Crouch's language, it leads to the innovation of instruments, not devices. Whereas devices remove human input and interaction—offering immense power at the push of a button—instruments extend human input.

The world needs both more instruments and more musicians, which means every Christian should aim for an embrace of technological advancement which leads to the development of more and better instruments. This kind of work can begin in the church. Inasmuch the church of Jesus Christ is, as the Fathers argued, the "ark" where the remnant of God remains safe from the raging chaos of the world, the church also embraces technology to construct itself into a safe place for both life and culture: stone buildings, bound bibles, intricately made pianos, and well-printed hymnals.

The Yellow Light: Production

The second space into which we naturally invite technological advancement is that of production. The earliest and most simple of technologies are bent towards this purpose. When Adam was called by God to "work the ground and keep it", perhaps in his pre-fall condition he only needed to harvest ripe fruit with his bare hands. But it's difficult to imagine him working the ground, full of the thorny curse of Genesis 3, without a shovel or rake. In many ways, productive technologies are human and life-giving, increasing our capacity for hard work and the strength of our own bodies.

Technology can also be part of the God-given grace needed to reduce the load of work, and therefore in turn lead to the ability to produce art and culture. In his renowned work Leisure: The Basis of Culture, Joseph Pieper argues that the ability for a society to cease from work is necessary to create anything truly lasting and worthwhile. “Leisure” says Pieper, "is not a Sunday afternoon idyll, but the preservation of freedom, of education and culture, and of that undiminished humanity which views the world as a whole.” If this is true, then the ability provided by certain productive technologies to allow for normal, working class men and women to rest from their labor is a kind of cultural good. If two men are given only one day and two shovels to move a huge mound of dirt, how can they hope to find rest? But if two men are given a skid-steer loader, they can both accomplish the task before them in the allotted time and get off work early to boot.

But by accomplishing in one day what two men with shovels would take one week to do, the skid-steer teaches us to depend on, and in fact expect or even yearn for, its superior efficiency. A society that replaces the virtue of patience with that of efficiency in turn replaces rest for empty leisure. As Crouch argues, empty leisure is a cheap rest that depends on other’s hard work and only medicates the despair we feel from lives filled with empty toil. This is why the Christian must be very careful to bring technology into the sphere of production, lest he find Pharaoh demanding more and more bricks with less and less straw.

The Red Light: Formation

Whereas the latest technology used to be reserved for the hospital and the assembly line, now it is tested in the places of moral, spiritual, and intellectual formation: the home, the school, and the church. Formation spaces are not where things are made, but where people are. It is in the home, the school, and the church where we learn our morals and values, take up our first ideas and projects, and discover the good, true, and beautiful. And it is these spaces that are in most danger of being invaded by the technium and producing a kind of counter-formation.

The reason formative spaces cannot be short-circuited with technological power is that they require resistance training. Just as muscles must be torn and stretched in order to grow back stronger, so must bodies and souls. If the promise of devices is easy power, then to continually utilize them in formative spaces is like, in Crouch’s words, “taking a forklift to the gym.” At first, it’s kind of fun, maybe even impressive. But eventually it’s boring, and it never results in making you more physically strong. Many of our formative spaces have lost the ability to produce young people who become persons of weight: someone who has a mind and a soul that is strong enough to bear the difficulties of life and persevere to the end.

When technological power invades the places of formation, it tends to make disciples after its own kind. Short-form videos breed short attention spans, consumeristic algorithms birth vapid consumers, and easy-solutions produce thin wills. We all know that phones and laptops in school have not led to greater educational success. It’s obvious to all of us that exposing children to more and more screentime is harming their development. Is anyone really arguing that using AI to write college essays is anything other than intellectual stagnation and academic dishonesty? And yet, the rolling

stone is hard to stop once it has been pushed downhill.

I believe it can be stopped in the church. The people of God must be stalwartly devoted to breaking any dependence on technological power in their spiritual formation. It should be their joy to meet the trials that come with being less efficient and more human, because, as James says: "you know that the testing of your faith produces steadfastness." Our ministry to children should be slow, embodied, personal, and focused on exposing the beauty of the Lord. Our ministry to youth should be over dinner tables and backyard games. Our formation of the soul should be less content and more conversation, less solution and more shoulder to cry on.

In order for Christ to be formed in the hearts of his people, we need more Christian leaders who are committed to the slow "anguish of child birth" (Galatians 4:19). Sometimes spiritual formation takes decades, and it is never without birth pains. Who is strong enough to wait it out? After all, our Savior did not take any short cuts. In re-forming the world towards the bent of justice and redemption, the only technology Christ utilized was the torturous cross.

The options before us in the technological world do not have to be between adoption and abandonment. We can maintain our humanity—limitation, relationship, purpose—without removing ourselves from the world completely. But it takes intentional choices, and the commitment to slow, patient formation in the way of Jesus.



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Misunderstanding Porn

MATTHEW LOFTUS

How can we stop men from looking at porn?

There is a growing group of online provocateurs who claim that porn would cease to be a problem if more wives lost weight and turned themselves into their husband's own "personal porn star." (I wish I was kidding.)

This assumes that every man is walking around with some sort of horniness quotient that can be fulfilled through orgasm, much like every human requires 1500-2000 calories per day to survive. Just as one can get those calories through a grande frappuccino or a dinner of beans and rice, so people seem to assume that one can have this quotient satisfied through some kind of sexual activity.

This "horniness quotient" hypothesis (let's call it HQ for short) is untrue. While the redpill influencers represent this view taken to its extreme, their misunderstanding is found more broadly. As deep and powerful as a person's sexual desires are, no one will die if they are denied sexual release. A husband whose wife gets a terrible stomach virus on the night of their wedding anniversary will be disappointed, but he will not waste away from sexual starvation if he has to wait another week or two before the next time they come together. If watching porn was simply

a matter of sexual release, it would not be the social catastrophe that it is. There are many ways in which people misunderstand porn, but perhaps the best way to summarize the corrections necessary is to say that porn is not the same as physical sex and porn addiction is not merely a matter of sexual temptation.

It may seem obvious to say that porn and sex with another person are not equivalent, but the confusion about this lack of interchangeability is fueling tolerance towards porn-watching and encouraging people to make excuses for those who are corroding their souls through this behavior. It is undoubtedly encouraging people who are watching porn to make excuses for themselves.

The Problem

Despite a multitude of filters, books, resources, conferences, articles, and men's groups, Christians are still watching a lot of porn and reporting that they're addicted. (The more religiously observant someone is, the less likely they are to watch porn.) Sadly, more and more Christians are not only watching porn, but they are also more likely to think watching porn is no big deal. This problem is not going away anytime soon.

There is already an abundance of resources explaining why watching porn is bad and how to quit (or how to help people you love quit), so this essay is not about those things. Rather, it's about correcting misunderstandings about porn that lead people who don't value the pursuit of holiness to make excuses for watching porn. Among Christians who believe that sex is a gift of God designed for marriage, a belief in the HQ seems to sneak in from time to time. These misunderstandings also confuse and frustrate Christians who understand, on some level, that watching porn is bad: how could any Christian invite such evil into their minds, particularly Christian husbands who can and do have sex with their wives?

There are probably some people for whom porn is functionally equivalent to sex—they feel sexual desire, they watch porn and masturbate, and then it's over and done. Yet this is not the typical activity of a porn addict. They are often scrolling for hours and hours, searching for more and more intense highs. Very often this leads to a search for images that are more varied and extreme—few men, for example, start off looking at child porn, but tend to seek it out after looking at adults starts to bore them. Porn is a hyperpleasure, a divorce from reality that reshapes the minds of those who watch it until it begins to define all of their interactions. Like opioid addicts who no longer get high but use drugs just to feel "normal" and avoid withdrawal, so porn addicts are often miserable whenever they are not looking at porn.

There is a natural confusion between the nature of porn addiction and the act of looking at porn itself. This is entirely understandable for people who do not look at porn and is especially painful for wives who first discover their husband's pornography addiction: why is an otherwise decent Christian man doing something that he knows to be sinful, harmful, and time-wasting? Why can't a porn addict's habit be broken by sex with his wife?

The simplest answer is to ask another question: could a Christian husband's temptation to idolatry be broken by sex with his wife? Of course not. Neither would his anger or pride. It is like asking if

a person addicted to cocaine could have their desire satisfied by eating a delicious steak. If someone's choice to sin by looking at porn is merely a matter of sexual temptation, then overcoming this temptation is simply a matter of growing closer to Christ, and Paul's exhortation that couples give generously to one another in 1 Corinthians 7 should be heeded. If it's more than that, we have a much bigger problem on our hands.

Someone who is addicted to porn is almost never simply tempted by sex. For porn addicts (and many non-addicts), looking at porn is not merely a matter of giving in to sexual temptation because they are facing a whole host of other temptations. They are using porn to deal with other problems in their lives. The temptation to look at porn, in many cases, is a temptation to pride, acedia, control, despair, or any other number of sins—which is why having sex, even good marital sex, cannot fix the problem. Men who are addicted to porn can even experience a profound sense of disappointment when they have sex with their wives—for if they are hoping to get from marital intimacy what they are used to getting from porn, they will inevitably be unsatisfied.

The Solution

Addiction is not one thing, but it is at least both a disease and a choice. Medical and psychiatric authorities may not recognize porn addiction as an addiction, but it bears enough similarity to other behavioral addictions like gambling to be taken seriously as such. Even if one rejects the idea of addiction as a disease, it is undeniable that the first time someone chooses to look at porn is very different from the 500th time he or she chooses to look at porn. Breaking any addiction requires a whole host of changes to one's life.

Recovery from porn addiction requires a wide variety of new behaviors. There is a spectrum between a purely practical intervention like an internet filter and spiritual transformation to fully appreciate the grace and love of God. It is incredibly difficult for Christians to "just say no" and white-knuckle their way through temptation when they do not give thought to all of the different temptations that porn represents for them and the different hurts that they have been using porn to numb. Indeed, many recovering porn addicts will have to take an extended period of abstinence (90 days is generally recommended) in order to train themselves to live well without sex and give their wives time to heal from the wounds caused by their betrayal.

Redpill influencers are quick to blame "dead bedrooms" and a lack of wifely vigor for men's choices to look at porn, but the reality that every addict must face is that they have a choice to sin or not. For some men, their porn addiction was a means of self-medicating profound trauma like sexual abuse when they were children. For others, an incredibly stressful job or a terrible marriage led them to seek out porn. In any case, no matter what happened to them, it is up to porn addicts to make their lives better by staying sober from porn.

Every addict learns at some point that even if they have described a good explanation for why they started or continued using porn, it is up to them whether they will choose to sin or not going forward. Recovery involves not only dealing with past issues that played a role in someone's addiction, but also preventing relapses when they encounter

new griefs, disappointments, or disruptions. Even if a husband is being mistreated in his marriage (or a man is being mistreated by society, another common trope on social media), it is up to him whether or not he will make his life worse by self-medicating with porn.

Most marriages will have ebbs and flows in their sexual intensity; bearing, breastfeeding, and raising small children all sap a wife's energy for lovemaking (both physiologically and mentally.) Christians who do not learn sexual continence will be miserable whether they are married or not, for sexual sin will create deeper and deeper forms of hunger the more that it is indulged. Porn in particular will destroy a person's appreciation for all of life's joys and make real sex feel miserable compared to the hyperreality of virtual licentiousness. A man's HQ can go to infinity if he chooses to allow Satan to take him to the bottom of that pit.

The good news is that God forgives us our sins and draws us near to Him. Hanging on the Cross, Jesus Christ saw us porn addicts watching vile things and still chose to remain there so that our lives could be redeemed. The Holy Spirit gives us power to overcome sin. The God-given plasticity of our brains means that we can construct elaborate prisons in our minds to help trap us in sin, but those prisons can be torn down and rebuilt as altars to worship God.

The meaning of sex is ultimately eschatological. All erotic longings are ultimately longings for the source of all goodness, and lately I have been praying that God would help me understand that my sexual temptation is merely a desire for Him that has been misdirected. Understanding the depth and shape of that misdirection will help people stop making excuses for sin and start helping sinners recover.



MATTHEW GREW UP IN A FAMILY OF 15 CHILDREN AND COMPLETED HIS MEDICAL TRAINING IN BALTIMORE, MARYLAND. SINCE 2015, HE AND HIS FAMILY HAVE LIVED IN EAST AFRICA, WHERE HE CURRENTLY TEACHES AND PRACTICES FAMILY MEDICINE AT A MISSION HOSPITAL. HIS WORK HAS APPEARED IN OUTLETS SUCH AS THE NEW YORK TIMES, THE ATLANTIC, THE NEW ATLANTIS, AND MERE ORTHODOXY AND HIS FIRST BOOK IS FORTHCOMING FROM INTERVARSITY PRESS. YOU CAN LEARN MORE ABOUT HIS WORK AND WRITING AT WWW.MATTHEWANDMAGGIE.ORG AND PREORDER HIS FORTHCOMING BOOK HERE: HTTPS://WWW.IVPRESS.COM/RESISTING-THERAPY-CULTURE

Why It Is Difficult to Talk About Ethics of the Body

HALEY BAUMEISTER

"When I came in and sat down and looked around, I realized it was a Roman Church full of plaster statues and bad art, realistic art. I hated the statues; all the emphasis on the human body. I was trying to escape from the human body and all it needed... I saw the bodies standing around me on all the altars... and I remembered that they believed in the resurrection of the body, the body that I wanted destroyed forever.

But could my vapor love that scar? And then I began to want that body that I hated, but only because it could love that scar. We can love with our minds but can we love only with our minds?"

~ Graham Greene, The End of the Affair

What do we immediately think of when ethical discussions around the body, sexuality, and procreation arise? What intuitions immediately surface? We get a layer or two underneath these reactions by asking, "What's behind that?"

In Carl Trueman's 2020 book The Rise and Triumph of the Modern Self, he writes,

Central to understanding the world in which we live is the concept of the social imaginary. This concept highlights that the tremendous changes we are witnessing can be interpreted through a variety of lenses. First, it is important to understand that most of us do not think about the world in the way we do because we have reason from first principles, to a comprehensive understanding of the cosmos. Rather, we generally operate on the basis of intuitions that we have unconsciously absorbed from the culture around us.

Conversations around fertility and bioethics fascinate me. It's not so much the explicit arguments or official teaching which intrigue me, but the reflexive ways in which these discussions often unfold.

The Rise and Triumph of the Modern Self is an exploration of our current air of expressive individualism, the sexual revolution, and how the confluence has given rise to phenomena such as the normalization of transgenderism. Much of this book echoed Abigail Favale's The Genesis of Gender as a "how we got here" type of journey.

For instance, he writes,

The increasing power of technology "fueled a view that the world was increasingly the raw material of human creativity, not the act of divine creation. The social imaginary emerging in the 19th century was one that intuitively placed human beings as the sovereigns at the center of a universe to which they could give shape and significance.

Issues surrounding "biblical sexuality", in vitro fertilization, surrogacy, transgenderism or the general culture of death and absolute procreative control provide opportunity for reflection on which areas we see as morally urgent (if at all), and which are left out in matters of sexuality.

What struck me while going through this book was how much of it illuminated patterns in discussions of fertility and bioethics with many conservative Christians. The prominence of emotivism as the sole driver of moral action is one. The reality of human nature and its relationship to medicine is another. And the two feed off each other.

Emotivism and Untethered Compassion

Trueman:

Human beings may like to think they still believe in good and bad, but these concepts are unhitched from any transcendent framework and merely reflect personal, emotional, and psychological preferences. In practice, it is we who decide our own preferred ends—and shape our ethics to that purpose. Any greater sense of purpose, any transcendent teleology, is now dead and buried.

Most conversations we now have about the medicalization of fertility — whether suppressing or erasing it through medicalized forms of contraception, or forcing it through in vitro fertilization — begin with an emotional framing. This is simply how we are as humans. It is normal and is not in and of itself bad! Such sentiments have their place in the workings of the soul. These deep wells of emotion and desire are, however, nothing stable to build moral reasoning upon.

Trueman continues:

What is true about abortion can be extrapolated into other areas. In our contemporary society, sexual morality has become largely a matter of pragmatic considerations. Will this make me happy? How can I attenuate the risks? Does it harm someone else's psychological wellbeing? And because these measures are always changing and are frequently subjective, they provide no stable framework for ethics.

In cases of removing fertility through medicalized forms of contraception, there are many common reasons people give for avoiding pregnancy generally. We likely know them ourselves. For our purposes, we won't focus on the discernment process or particular reasons. The point being, we can see this is simply where many conversations begin: "I feel a certain way about X reality. We have a reason to want X."

In cases of forcing a chance at pregnancy through in vitro fertilization, there is most certainly a couple in the depths of grief. They have likely been bowled over by deep longings their bodies have not allowed them to realize. Of course these are valid emotions anyone would have, and any one of us would experience the same if put in the position of being open to children and not receiving them. Again, this is simply where conversations begin: "I feel a certain way about X reality. We have a reason to want X."

In a long essay exploring the morphing of the healing profession over time, I wrote:

Oliver O'Donovan, in his 1984 book Begotten or Made?, a treatment of personhood and the fitting boundaries of reproductive techniques, identifies how a blind virtue of compassion—when untethered from anything beyond itself—can become the driving motivator for action: 'Compassion is the virtue of being moved to action by the sight of suffering–that is to say, by the infringement of passive freedoms. It is a virtue that circumvents thought, since it prompts us immediately to action. It is a virtue that presupposes that an answer has already been found to the question "What needs to be done?," a virtue of motivation rather than of reasoning. As such it is the appropriate virtue for a liberal revolution, which requires no independent thinking about the object of morality, only a very strong motivation to its practice.'

In Trueman's book, he proposes that we have been a therapeutic culture for a long time. In the absence of a sacred order this means Psychological Man reigns, and is guided by the sentiments of the self.

He writes,

These cultures are really just therapeutic cultures, the cultures of Psychological Man. The only moral criterion that can be applied to behavior is whether it produces feelings of wellbeing in the individual." "Ethics, therefore, becomes a function of feeling... because there is no greater purpose that can be justified in any ultimately authoritative sense. ...

In a world of empathy-based ethics, the moral sense is basically the aesthetic sense. And that means when the sacred order collapses, morality is simply a matter of taste, not truth.

A collapsed sacred order. Feelings of well-being.

Untethered compassion. Empathy-based ethics.

Our emotions desire a certain end. Pathos longs for something to be true, to change reality to fit the desire. This is understandable! Untethered from any further sense of what is good about the created order, however, Christians are just as prone to thinking like those who are not seeking to live before the face of God their Maker.

Trueman observes:

In this context, it is interesting to note how much of the debate about sexuality in Christian circles likewise tends to operate in terms of personal narratives, isolated from any larger metaphysical or theological framework. Even in the church, personal stories have a powerful, emotional impact that can easily transform the chief end of human beings into the personal happiness that stands at the heart of the therapeutic culture.

He notes the arguments that same-sex and transgender couples now deserve the right to their own families via assisted reproductive technology. It is interesting to observe how many conservations around procreation and IVF for other couples hold similar sentiments."This, in turn, points to the function of the family as being primarily therapeutic. It is about the sense of psychological well-being of the parents."

Emotivism in the realm of ethics is also amplified when we are confronted with moral dilemmas and potential action "at the bedside," as it were. Proactive approaches are always better than reactive ones. Times of urgency and emotional pressure are never helpful times to be confronted with issues never before considered. We need the moral sensibilities of our bodily life shaped before then.

Trueman writes that, "The movement of sexual problems from the sphere of morality to the sphere of medicine is one that continues today, as society's strong preference for technical—rather than moral—approaches indicates."

For our purposes, that means there is a need to provide theological, practical, and relational tools for navigating the reality of our bodies in ways that retain a sense of their sacredness over mere utility. Farming out our imaginations about sexuality to rudimentary sex ed in high school and medical professionals has not worked out swimmingly thus far. We need truer, more whole stories. After all, ignorance during times when such knowledge doesn't seem pressing can later become a matter of urgency. A lack of thought in the beginning will lead to barren formation in the end. These are simultaneously physiological, relational, and ethical issues.

Consider the girl (or woman) who has never learned the basics of her reproductive cycle, what symptoms are concerning, which deserve proper investigation and care, or what ovulation and the monthly window of fertility is, or how she can expect such variations throughout the month to affect her physically and mentally.

Consider the engaged couple who has never learned or considered the same—and weren't encouraged to—prior to marriage.

We know what happens with women and girls who have physical complaints or concerns in most doctor's offices. We also know what happens with

spouses who haven't been taught to mutually learn and respect their bodies in marriage. Medicalization in the form of hormonal contraception can be a bandaid given from providers for deeper maladies which deserve deeper investigation and care. Such medicalization is a way to offload ongoing participation and responsibility, or of sidestepping the annoyance of friction and the need for attentiveness in sexual relationships.

Consider the couple struggling with infertility. This is an emotional—and simultaneously physiological—experience. They may not have considered, prior to their very real crisis, the workings or health of their reproductive systems. They may not have been directed to providers trained in Restorative Reproductive Medicine or NaProTechnology—which aim to live up to the name of the healing profession when it comes to seeking restoration of both overall and reproductive health. Most traditional medical providers have limited tools and time for investigating root causes of infertility. Therefore, many are referred to IVF without so much as a proper diagnosis (let alone investigation) into particular, common causes of "unexplained infertility."

We need to consider our bodies—and help our fellow Christians do the same—prior to becoming deer in headlights under the weight of desperate, emotional pressure to instrumentalize our bodies. If our bodies matter at all to our faith then this, too, is spiritual work.

Human Nature

Trueman:

Take away the idea of universal human nature, and ethics sends into the subjective emotivism that MacIntyre sees as characterizing our present age. Empathy on its own is liable not just to sentiment, but to degenerate into a sentimentalism that simply wants other people to be happy in their own way, on their own terms. It is the collapse of this meta-concept of human nature that will prove so critical...

What things are behind many of our assumptions when talking about the body?

Kelly Garrison, in her article A Return to Love, writes a gentle plea for clearer vision about what is true of human nature and thus of our approach to sexuality: "any lessons about sex and anatomy must focus on the body as it is—that is, vulnerable, fertile, mortal—not what we wish it to be."

What are we wishing the body would be? What might be preventing us from living within the limits of the body as it is? In essence, "What's behind that?" is an invaluable question.

The Glorious Goodness of It

The word "just" can strip the beauty out of anything special, intimate, or sacred. It's worth asking how we have come to feel that way about our bodies. It's "just some flesh, just biological functions." We do not believe this about other matters of sexuality. I wonder at what point we believe the body does start being meaningful?

We will leave that to others embracing the issue of embodiment more broadly. I remain fascinated by the things we do to our fertility, and the practice of procreation outside of the marital bond.

The Medicalized Transformation of It

In her essay Religio Medici, Kristin M. Collier explains:

Our bodies, our histories, our relationships are given before they are chosen. They have a radically "thrown" quality; we come into the world already dependent on parents and other caregivers, on the natural world, on social structures we did not design, and above all on God. Our lives are not things we own so much as vocations we receive. To forget this is not only a theological error; it has practical consequences that are both numerous and baleful. When the body is seen as raw material for self-expression or self-construction, any limit—mortality, disability, vulnerability, infertility, aging—becomes a kind of insult. Technology then appears as the liberator that can free us from these indignities. The goal of medicine shifts from caring for the body as given and toward redesigning it... The "can" of technological possibility quickly becomes a "should."

Consider especially her comment about the limits of our body becoming a sort of insult. What parts of our humanity insult, distress, or annoy us? In what ways do we think medical technology ought not just heal what is amiss, but free us from parts of our nature we no longer want?

Trueman again:

The idea of self-creation, that we can shape our essences by acts of will, is deeply embedded in the way we think... weakening, and even abolishing, the idea that human nature is a given—something that has an intrinsic, non-negotiable authority over who we are.

Medical techniques and attitudes have been reshaping our view of our bodies, sexuality, and procreation in ways that have nothing to do with healing or aiming toward true health. Rather, the healing profession has, in various ways, turned into a means of fulfilling psychological desires of what we want to be true about ourselves.

C. S. Lewis draws a similar parallel in The Abolition of Man.

There is something which unites magic and applied science while separating both from the wisdom of earlier ages. For the wise men of old the cardinal problem had been how to conform the soul to reality, and the solution had been knowledge, self-discipline, and virtue. For magic and applied science alike the problem is how to subdue reality to the wishes of men: the solution is a technique; and both, in the practice of this technique, are ready to do things hitherto regarded as disgusting and impious...

Perhaps we were meant to form our souls to reality. But now, we bend the nature of the body to the will.

"...then the problem becomes one of the body, one to be treated with medication and surgery. Technology, therefore, makes the whole claim plausible. Technology, one might even say, defines ontology." This defining of ontology, Trueman goes on to observe, is "fueled by a powerful individualism, and facilitated by a technological ability to manipulate biological realities... thanks to surgery and hormones, and modern medical breakthroughs, we can now plausibly separate gender from sex and even revise the relationship of the sexes to the means of reproduction."

In a word, "Take away the notion of human nature, and all that is left is free-floating subjective sentiment." Likewise, in an interview at the Public Discourse, Angela Franks shares that,

The modern rejection of substance rejected the need to have linguistic clarity around who and what the triune God and Jesus Christ are. I think the motive for that is really just the modern obsession with freedom. Because if I am not limited by a certain nature, by my human nature, if I am not limited by being this finite substance, then this whole new world of possibilities opens up. ... Yet transgenderism is only the latest and most extreme form of this movement... it is a symptom, not a cause.

We can have sex stripped of procreative powers before its time. We can have the gratification of biological children obtained through any means necessary.

Hayden Nesbit writes in his reflection on Resonance and the Psalms,

Indeed, one of the casualties of trying to control the nature of the world is that we distort its true nature. Creation by nature speaks to us, but we have rendered it mute by our incessant attempt to master it through control.

In muting the design of the created order, it also seems possible to mute our moral sensibilities. It's hard to talk about something one can no longer see. Medicalizing our sexuality—whether to be rid of fertility or to force a pregnancy—is so commonplace, it is no longer a matter of robust consideration. It no longer factors in our spiritual or moral formation. It is not just underappreciated. It is often not even on the map.

Why does this matter? Why should we care about any of this? Erik Varden offers an answer:

Faith in the Son of God made man requires of me an embodied response, made concrete in a life of conversion, not just in the rehearsal of abstract sublimities.

Our Own Formation

What does the Christian life consist of? Is it rehearsing abstract sublimities of theological truths? Does it include embodied responses, humble faith made concrete?

I've been thinking about spiritual discipleship and how moral formation goes hand in hand with it. In this way, our inner dispositions find outward expression.

Bodily and particularly sexual ethics reinforce ways of being in the world. They reinforce what we believe about what it means, or doesn't, to live set apart lives. They reinforce what we think it means to live as awe-filled, obedient, and very loved creatures "before the face of God."

Do we see the face behind such an invitation?

We need the orthodoxy of proper theology and doctrine. We need the orthopraxy of right living and moral action—to show our orthodoxy makes sense in the world. We also need the orthopathy of ordered passion and affections. In The Abolition of Man, C.S. Lewis describes this dance when he says "the head rules the belly through the chest."

Our bodies were designed with intention and declared good. Our sexual lives in marriage were meant to be nourishing of the marriage itself. Of course, this comes by way of pleasure and subsequent emotional bonding. If we look at God's intention for the blessing and sanctification that is offered in marriage, I can't help but think we were meant to press into the reality of being one flesh in the sharing of our procreative potential. I can't help thinking the friction of getting to navigate our biological workings of our bodies is actually a feature, not a bug to dispose of as we wish. Pleasure is one way we are united. The other is in the way we handle and communicate the reality of our shared fertility.

The prospect of this confronts us with many emotions about many things. Physiological factors ebb and flow throughout the month. Mood changes affect our communication. We have desires, frustrations, longings, or fears about pregnancy and parenting. We all struggle in what to talk about and when to do so.

These are also invitations to be formed as a couple and individually into the likeness of Christ. How closely do husbands pay attention to the bodily life of their wife, as one flesh with her, as a husband living with her in an understanding way? How closely do both pay attention to the layer or two beneath longings, fears, frustrations, desires for control, openness to God's voice? How will both be confronted with the disposition behind related issues in our hearts and marriages? Bumping up against the grain of our humanity—and especially the procreative nature of sexuality—can reveal much. How will we find out what's there if we refuse this invitation of patience and forbearance?

How else does formation work except ultimately through our bodies? Formation happens through what we choose to do—the habituation of the fruit of the Spirit, the habituation of virtue. Christian tradition says we practice virtue to gain the virtue.

Of course we want what we want immediately. We don't want to keep choosing it over and over. We don't want to keep having to deal with our pesky bodies. But there are challenging, tender, soul-stretching experiences we miss out on with our spouse and with God when we are not willing to do that.

We are catechized by what we believe, but perhaps more so by what we do. What we do in the body catechizes the soul at a deep level. It can catechizes the conscience. Things spoken, heard, permitted, practiced, endorsed over time forms prominent grooves, dulling us to what might otherwise have disturbed us.

Like the unassuming but steady stream of water, our souls are formed for ill but also for good. I wonder how much we've lost the ability to notice the water itself—this "social imaginary"—which wears grooves into our personal and communal intuitions.

In an essay considering paths of spiritual formation, Leah says "Christians know we are to grow in Christlikeness; we are tempted to believe that we have the foresight and wisdom to determine what will get us there."

We can choose to accept being a creature crafted by our Maker. We can choose to live more fully within the grain of our given bodies, within the

limits of our flesh. Transformation might come.

If we have healthy fertility, we can choose to accept the friction that comes with receiving it and navigating it for the years it's given to us. If we have broken bodies, we can choose to pursue the healing of whatever is not functioning as intended. If we have bodies that cannot—for anatomical reasons or factors we have pursued restoration of—bring forth children from our marriage bond, these are realities that can burst with devastating grief. We need a robust, Christian vision of what living within the limits of our flesh looks like—for the blessedly fertile, for the sick and struggling, and for the infertile.

Our crosses are ours to bear, and the blessings found in those crosses ours to receive. This is the way of the Christian life. We worship the incarnated Christ. He took on flesh in order to pour it out, and so our own bodies and physical laments take on meaning. The body holds the ways in which we were made to know Him, in all the delights and suffering along the way. It is ours to receive, as bought with a price and given in love.

If Christianity is good news, we need to show in our very selves that it is. That trusting Him and living under His sacred order is not an intellectual exercise, but flows into the whole of life—including our bodies, sexuality, pregnancy and parenting. We can trust Him and submit to Him in our flesh, because we are the clay and not the potter. As Erik Varden puts it, "Once our eyes have been opened to faith as something real, a reorientation of existence is called for."

Reoriented and freed from postures of utility, we might yet find there is work the Lord wants to do in us—work not in spite of, but in the midst of—our finite selves. The boundaries have fallen for us in pleasant places.

We are invited to become humble enough to be molded with firm hands. Hands that can form His image from dust and bone. Hands that can form us through the fleshy means He chose for us. Hands that have only ever worked for our good.

He is not a harsh taskmaster. Will we allow the potter to do His work?

The Christian Witness

I've heard it said that the question of the first millenium was "Who is Christ?" (and thus, the councils and creeds). The question of the second millennium was "Who is the Church?" (and thus the Reformation). The question of the third millenium might very well turn out to be "Who is Man?" (and thus our response to technologically-driven anthropological questions which arise about the body, sexuality, and procreation).

Our moral reasoning and action is never confined to our own life. It does not affect only ourselves. What we believe are merely personal decisions are in fact theological statements and anthropological in nature. They contribute to a slow drip which affects ecosystems and props up plausibility structures for ways of thinking about our body, sex, and procreation.

And so, our collective formation is the Christian witness. Individual action can dilute or make more potent the witness of the whole. We are in the midst of an anthropological crisis about the human person, sexuality, and why our bodies even matter at all.

Faced with massive disembodiment, sexual disorder, and bodily desecration, we need a coherent vision of the human person to share with the world. Let us show—and not just tell—that another creaturely life is possible.

May we be found speaking true things with our earthen vessels, the temples of the Holy Spirit.

Its essence is not ours to refashion, wish away, or transcend. Any proclamations to the culture around us regarding the goodness of living within the bounds of God's created order—especially in the realm of sexuality—first needs to be true of ourselves.

Otherwise, we will remain scandalized by certain sexual practices and procedures out there, not seeing how our imaginations have been cut from the same cloth. We, too, resist the limitations and friction of our bodies. We, too, bend our sexual nature to our will.

To change course, Trueman suggests Protestants must revive natural law and a high view of the body, before wagging fingers at the world around us.

Which brings us back to my original realization—that a book about the attitudes and plausibility structures which fostered transgenderism are the same ones a person bumps up against when discussing fertility and bioethics with even conservative Christians.

Matthew Lee Anderson wrote that his book Earthen Vessels

argued that evangelicalism had tacitly adopted secular practices and habits through inattentiveness to our bodily life. It is not our explicit affirmations and denials that matter, I suggested, but what happens beneath the surfaces and outside the edges of our view. But that means the way to recover a community and a society of people who value the goodness of bodily life in its fullness is not through reducing the chief expressions of our public witness to the last, thin thread of sexual ethics that we can all still agree on. Rather, we must set about rediscovering and reviving the broad and beautiful backdrop of the goodness of mortal flesh, a goodness we have each denied in a thousand different ways. We cannot authentically or authoritatively name and resist the "spirit of our age" until we recognize that before the world made Caitlyn Jenner, we made it.



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